

Ending Homelessness in Toronto

How do we end homelessness in Toronto — stop the inflow by taking away its root causes, make our shelter and emergency system the best in the world, and rapidly house everyone who's homeless today — for less than we pay now to maintain the crisis?

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The question this book answers: *How do we end homelessness in Toronto — stop the inflow by taking away its root causes, make our shelter and emergency system the best in the world, and rapidly house everyone who's homeless today — for less than we pay now to maintain the crisis?*

Foreword

This book has no author's name on it, by design. What follows is one citizen's synthesis of the public evidence on homelessness in Toronto — assembled from municipal audits, budget documents, peer-reviewed research, court decisions, and the City's own counts of its homeless population, with every claim traced back to a public source. It advances no personal story and claims no personal authority; its only claim is to have read the record carefully and cited it honestly.

Where the evidence is strong, this book says so plainly. Where it is thin, contested, or not yet independently verified, it says that too, in the open, rather than smoothing over the gap. Figures that could not be confirmed against a primary source are marked as such rather than presented as settled fact. A fuller accounting of sources, methods, and the verification trail behind every claim in this book is kept separately — see Receipts & Methods.

The reader is invited to check every figure against its source and to hold this synthesis to the same standard it tries to hold the City, the province, and the federal government: show your work, or don't claim the finding.

The Case, Compressed

Before the full argument, here is the same case at three lengths — a handful of lines, one sentence, and one paragraph. Everything that follows in this book is the expansion of what is stated here.

In a few lines

"A shelter bed costs Toronto \$49,640 a year. Housing First support: \$20,367 — \$6,311 after the savings it creates." — Auditor General of Toronto (per-bed figures supplied by Toronto Shelter and Support Services and reported by the Auditor General, not independently audited by the AG), annualized; Latimer et al., "Cost-Effectiveness of Housing First With Assertive Community Treatment," *Psychiatric Services*, 2020.

"Ontario Works' shelter allowance only exists once you already have a home to pay for. Without one, Ontario Works pays a single adult \$343 a month — 13 cents of every poverty-line dollar." — Ontario Works Policy Directives 6.1 ("a homeless person... will receive an amount for basic needs, but will not receive an amount for shelter until a dwelling is retained") and 6.3; \$4,116 a year against the Market Basket Measure poverty line of \$31,440 for a single adult in Toronto, 2025 (Statistics Canada). This figure is about Ontario Works itself, not total welfare income: refundable tax credits (the GST/HST credit and the Ontario Trillium Benefit, together roughly \$1,200–\$1,400 a year, depending on the Maytree accounting vintage used) bring total welfare income for a single adult on OW to roughly 17 cents of every poverty-line dollar.

"Ottawa cut Toronto's federal homelessness funding 68% this year." — City of Toronto Budget Notes: \$300 million (2025) to a budgeted \$97.078 million (2026), Toronto Shelter and Support Services.

"In winter 2023-24, Toronto lost 12,742 shelter bed-nights to process rules — while averaging 174 people a night unmatched." — Auditor General of Toronto, Warming Centres and Winter Respite audit, February 2025 (covering the 2023/24 season).

"Scotland put 2,154 people straight into homes. 83% are still housed." — Scottish Government, Housing First monitoring report, 2025.

"Toronto's homelessness is not a mystery. It's the product of five policy failures — most built in a single 1990s window." — See Chapter 2, The History.

"Every shelter bed should be a future apartment." — A design principle, not a measured fact: the direction this book argues the shelter system should be rebuilt to face.

In one sentence

Toronto can end homelessness — by shutting the five documented inflow pipelines, transforming the shelter system from a warehouse into a housing gateway, and housing everyone who is homeless today through Housing First — for less than the crisis already costs, IF all three governments fund the proven tools simultaneously, on a fixed public timeline, with Indigenous organizations governing as full partners.

In one paragraph

Homelessness at Toronto's scale is the traceable product of specific policy choices — funding withdrawals, discharge pipelines, and a shelter system redesigned by drift into permanent warehousing — which means it is reversible by specific policy choices. The evidence base is unusually strong: the Auditor General reports (TSSS-supplied figures) a shelter bed cost of roughly \$49,640 a year against \$20,367 gross / \$6,311 net in Housing First support (Latimer et al., 2020); Finland, Scotland, and Houston show the model scaling — and Finland's 2024–25 reversal shows it requires permanent commitment, not a one-time program. The shelter system's failures are documented in the City's own audits: bed-nights lost to process rules, a phone-only front door, and discharge streams from hospitals and corrections feeding the inflow. The plan: close the five inflow pipelines; rebuild the emergency system on the City's already-adopted shelter capital strategy as a diversion-first, health-integrated, Indigenous-led gateway; and house today's population through rent supplements, acquisition, and supportive units — at a net cost below the status quo, with every figure carried by a receipt and the strongest counterarguments answered in the open. All of this holds IF all three governments fund it simultaneously — the precondition this book states plainly at the outset and shows, in the chapters on the City's history and on the levers of power, has not been met once in twenty-seven years.

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Executive Summary

On the night of the City's most recent count, October 22, 2025, an estimated 12,196 people in Toronto had no home of their own — sleeping in the shelter system, in provincially run facilities, or outdoors (City of Toronto, [Street Needs Assessment research page](#)). That is 21% fewer than the all-time high of 15,418 counted a year earlier (City of Toronto, [2024 Street Needs Assessment](#), July 7, 2025) — a drop driven predominantly by the ebbing of the 2021–2024 refugee-claimant surge described in Chapter 1, not by City management or program improvement, per this book's own research base. But it is still 66% above the 7,347 people counted in April 2021, and Toronto now spends roughly \$786–\$898 million a year on shelters and homelessness services alone just to *manage* that population in a system built for emergencies, not for housing anyone permanently (City of Toronto, [2025 and 2026 Budget Notes, Toronto Shelter and Support Services](#)). Indigenous people are overrepresented in every count the City has taken since its first in 2006 — three- to sixteen-fold, depending on the measure and the year; Black Torontonians made up 58% of 2024 survey respondents while being roughly one-tenth of the city's population (City of Toronto, *2024 SNA*).

Homelessness at this scale is not a mystery, and it is not inevitable. It is the traceable product of specific policy decisions — most made in a five-year window in the 1990s — that this book walks through in Chapter 2: the federal government's 1993/94 withdrawal from funding new social housing, Ontario's 1995 cancellation of roughly 17,000 non-profit and co-op homes already underway alongside a 21.6% cut to welfare rates, the 1998 provincial "download" of housing and social-assistance administration onto municipalities, and the deinstitutionalization of psychiatric care without the community supports promised alongside it. Those choices produced Toronto's 1998 declaration of homelessness as a national disaster and the 105-recommendation Golden Report of January 1999. A quarter-century later, most of that report's core asks — dedicated, indexed funding for new social and supportive housing and for income supports that track the cost of rent — still have not been met at the scale required, and homelessness has climbed in nearly every count since.

For Indigenous people, this modern history sits on a much older and deeper one. Residential schools, the Sixties Scoop, and the continuing, disproportionate apprehension of Indigenous children into Ontario's child-welfare system are direct, documented drivers of the homelessness Indigenous Torontonians experience at what that report's own analysis

estimates as three to ten times the rate of the general population (City of Toronto Shelter, Support and Housing Administration and Toronto Indigenous Community Advisory Board, ["Indigenous Peoples' Experience of Homelessness in Toronto,"](#) June 12, 2023). This book treats the Indigenous dimension of the crisis not as a footnote but as a thread through every chapter — because ending homelessness in Toronto cannot be separated from reconciliation, and because Indigenous-led organizations already operating in this city are among the strongest evidence we have for what works.

This book argues Toronto can move from *managing* homelessness to *ending it as a mass, chronic condition* through four moves, each built on programs and institutions that already exist here:

1. **Stop the inflow** by closing the gap between what income supports pay and what rent costs, scaling eviction prevention that is already outperforming its targets, and fixing the institutional discharge pipelines (jails, hospitals, foster care) that hand people directly from an institution to the street (Chapter 3).
2. **Make the shelter and emergency system the best in the world** for the people who still need it — low-barrier, trauma-informed, genuinely 24/7, with a single point of access that does not turn people away — while it shrinks from a permanent housing substitute into what it should always have been: a short, safe bridge (Chapter 4).
3. **Rapidly rehouse everyone currently homeless within one year — conditional on landlord-recruitment and staffing benchmarks being met, the condition Chapter 9 itself prescribes**, using the same sequence that has worked everywhere Housing First has actually worked: portable rent supplements into the existing rental market first (fastest, cheapest), acquisition of existing buildings second, and fast-build modular and supportive housing third (Chapter 5).
4. **Redirect the money already being spent.** Canada's own At Home/Chez Soi trial found every \$10 invested in Housing First for the highest-needs participants nationally returned \$9.60 in avoided shelter, hospital, and justice costs, and 62% of Housing First participants were housed all of the time in the trial's last six months against 31% of the comparison group ([Mental Health Commission of Canada, *National At Home/Chez Soi Final Report*](#), 2014). Toronto's own site — high-needs cohort, 2014 report — did even better: every \$10 invested returned \$15.05 in avoided costs, on an intervention that cost \$21,089 per person per year and produced \$31,747 in service-cost reductions over the two-year study period; 80% of Toronto's Housing First participants were stably

housed at study end, against 54% of the comparison group ([Gozdzik et al., *At Home/Chez Soi Project: Toronto Site Final Report*](#), Mental Health Commission of Canada, 2014). Rebuilt bottom-up from the City's own audited unit-cost benchmarks and the delivery-tool mix Chapter 5 recommends, the one-time capital cost of permanently housing everyone currently homeless in Toronto falls in the range of **\$0.7 billion to \$1.5 billion**, depending on exactly how the population splits across rent supplements, acquisition, and modular build (see Receipts & Methods for the full scenario table). This book's recommended point estimate is the balanced scenario — 50% rent supplement / 30% acquisition / 20% modular build — at **\$1.01–\$1.49 billion** in capital and roughly **\$242 million a year** in ongoing Housing First support. Even applying the Auditor General's own measured 63% Modular Housing Initiative cost overrun to the most build-heavy, most pessimistic scenario modeled, the capital bill tops out at **\$2.24 billion** — still less than three years of the current shelter budget in every case, though in that worst case only just: 2.85 of 3.0 years (Chapter 7).

None of this requires inventing new tools. It requires Toronto, Ontario, and the federal government to fund, at scale and on a fixed timeline, things that are already proven here and elsewhere: Housing First (invented in New York, proven in Toronto's own *At Home/Chez Soi* trial), Built for Zero methodology (already used by Medicine Hat, Alberta, and London, Ontario), coordinated eviction prevention (already outperforming its ten-year target in Toronto after five), and Indigenous-led housing delivery (already running through Na-Me-Res, Wigwamen, and at least seven other City-funded or TASSC-member Indigenous organizations, with an eighth in development). Chapter 8 sets out the best-documented cases from around the world — Finland, Houston, Vienna, Scotland, and the cautionary tale of Utah — for Toronto to model itself on, and Chapter 6 is honest about the fact that the single biggest threat to any of this is not a missing idea but a missing dollar: federal funding for Toronto's refugee-response shelter costs was cut by roughly 68%, from \$300 million (2025) to a budgeted \$97.078 million (2026) (City of Toronto, 2026 TSSS Budget Notes, [backgroundfile-261532.pdf](#)).

Every recommendation in this book assumes no miracle. It works **if — and only if — Toronto, Ontario, and Ottawa fund these proven tools simultaneously, on a fixed public timeline**. That has not happened once in the twenty-seven years since the Golden Report. Chapter 6 examines why, and what would have to change for it to happen this time.

The Problem: Homelessness in Toronto Today

The scale, and how fast it moved

Toronto counts its homeless population through the Street Needs Assessment (SNA), a combined point-in-time count and survey the City has run periodically since 2006. The trend line is the starting fact of this whole report:

Count date	People counted	Change
April 2013	5,253	—
April 26, 2018	8,715	+66% vs. 2013
April 21, 2021	7,347	–16% vs. 2018 (COVID border closures cut refugee arrivals)
October 23, 2024	15,418	+110% vs. 2021
October 22, 2025	12,196	–21% vs. 2024

Sources: City of Toronto, [2021 Street Needs Assessment Results Report](#); [2024 Street Needs Assessment](#), July 2025; [Street Needs Assessment research page](#) (Oct. 2025 count).

The 2024 count broke down as 63% in City-administered shelters, 17% in bridging/triage programs, 10% in provincially administered facilities, and 10% outdoors — and of the 12,304 people in shelter or bridging programs, 6,350 were refugee claimants (City of Toronto, *2024 SNA*, July 2025). Toronto's shelter system is far larger than a single night's count suggests: average nightly occupancy was 9,010 in 2023 and roughly 9,700–9,800 in 2024–2025, but close to 22,000–24,200 *different* people cycled through the system across each of those years ([City of Toronto, "Shelter System Flow Data"](#); [2024 Toronto Shelter and Support Services Annual Report](#)). On the City's own throughput count, the shelter system served 20,700 unique individuals in 2022, a confirmed 27% increase over the 16,300 served in 2016 (City of Toronto, "City of Toronto update on shelter system capacity pressures," May 31, 2023). Even as the system has expanded, it has not kept pace with demand: an average of 278 callers a day were turned away from Toronto's Central Intake line unmatched to any bed in September 2023, falling to a projected 216/day in January 2025 and a targeted 125/day for 2026 — real progress, but still a daily queue of people with nowhere to go (City of

Toronto, [2025 Budget Notes](#) and [2026 Budget Notes](#), Toronto Shelter and Support Services).

The refugee claimant surge

Much of the 2021–2024 spike, and much of the 2025 improvement, traces to one population: refugee and asylum claimants. They were 13% of Toronto's homeless population in 2021 and over 50% by 2024, with average nightly shelter occupancy by claimants rising from roughly 530 a night in September 2021 to a peak of 6,490 on August 20, 2024 — more than an eleven-fold, roughly 1,125% increase (City of Toronto briefing note, March 19, 2025) — before falling to roughly 3,420–3,450 nightly as of September 2025. Mayor Olivia Chow's September 26, 2025 letter to Executive Committee states directly, "we now have 3,420 claimants in our shelter system... we are still providing shelter support for 3,450 refugee claimants every night," corroborated by an August 8, 2025 TSSS briefing-note figure of 3,528 and Chow's own August 21 public statement of "3,500 plus" (City of Toronto, *2024 SNA*; [Mayor Olivia Chow, letter to Executive Committee, "Cuts to Federal and Provincial Support for Housing,"](#) Sept. 26, 2025). This is squarely a *federal* responsibility colliding with a *municipal* budget: Ottawa's Interim Housing Assistance Program (IHAP), which reimburses cities for asylum-claimant shelter costs, lapsed without consultation in March 2023, was only partially reinstated that July, and Toronto has run funding gaps against it every year since — a \$103 million shortfall in 2023, a \$21.7 million gap in the 2025 budget, and Mayor Olivia Chow's public warning of a \$107 million shortfall in 2025–26 (City of Toronto, [Report for Action](#), Sept. 2023; [2025 Budget Notes](#); [Report EX26.13, Cuts to Federal and Provincial Support for Housing](#), 2025). Chapter 6 returns to this as the single clearest example of how a funding fight between governments lands directly on people sleeping outside.

Encampments

Encampment counts have swung sharply with the overall crisis: from roughly 82 tents across 24 parks in March 2023, to over 200 tents across 72 parks by March 2024, to a peak of 539 people across 107 parks in November 2024, down to approximately 196–330 people by late 2025 as the refugee surge eased and City outreach intensified ([City of Toronto, 2026 Budget Notes](#); [Global News, "Encampments reported in 48 Toronto parks, a 55% decrease,"](#) Dec.

2025). Ontario's courts have weighed in on how cities may respond: in *Heegsma v. Hamilton (City)*, 2024 ONSC 7154, the Ontario Superior Court upheld encampment by-law enforcement against a Charter challenge, holding that "the life, liberty and security of the applicants are not put at risk by enforcement of the by-law. They are put at risk by homelessness" — while declining to recognize an unlimited right to encamp on public land ([CanLII, Heegsma v. Hamilton \(City\), 2024 ONSC 7154](#)). Toronto has stated a preference for shelter-system and outreach responses over police-led clearing, though a 2023 Ombudsman investigation into the City's 2021 encampment clearings found the City had shown "significant unfairness" in how it carried that out.

Chronic homelessness, and what it costs in lives

Homelessness in Toronto is increasingly long-term, not episodic. In the 2021 SNA, 77% of respondents had been homeless for six months or more of the past year; by 2024 that had risen to 83%, with 66% homeless the *entire* prior twelve months and 49% homeless 18 or more of the preceding 36 months (City of Toronto, [2021 SNA Highlights](#); 2024 SNA). An administrative, case-tracked count put chronic homelessness at 7,688 individuals in 2024.

Toronto tracks homeless deaths through two separate systems that should not be confused. The City's own count of deaths among *shelter residents* — tracked since 2007 — recorded 59 deaths in 2024 and 59 again in 2025, a cumulative 884 since tracking began, with opioid overdose the leading identified cause ([City of Toronto, "Deaths of Shelter Residents"](#)).

Toronto Public Health's broader count of deaths among *all* people experiencing homelessness — including those outdoors — is far higher: 331 deaths in 2022, 300 in 2023, and 135 in just the first half of 2024, with drug toxicity responsible for roughly half ([City of Toronto, "Toronto Public Health releases updated data for deaths of people experiencing homelessness in Toronto,"](#) Feb. 3, 2025). The mortality gap this produces is stark: the median age at death for men experiencing homelessness was 50, against 78 for the general male population of Toronto; for women it was 36–43, against 85 for the general female population (same source). Homelessness in Toronto today shortens a life by roughly three decades.

Who is affected

The 2024 SNA found 57% of respondents male, 41% female, and 1% gender-diverse; 20% identified as 2SLGBTQ+; the average age was 41, but the average age at a person's *first* experience of homelessness was 35 — meaning most people counted are relatively new to homelessness even though, per above, most have now been homeless a long time once they enter it. Seventy-seven percent identified as racialized, including 58% who identified as Black, against roughly one-tenth of Toronto's general population; in the 2021 SNA, Black respondents were a confirmed 31% of the homeless population against roughly 9% of Toronto's general population (City of Toronto, *2021 SNA Results Report*; *2024 SNA*). Forty-one percent cited inadequate income as the reason they lost their housing — roughly double the share who said so in 2021 (City of Toronto, *2024 SNA*).

The Indigenous overlay: overrepresentation that has never gone away

Indigenous people are consistently and severely overrepresented in Toronto's homeless population, in every SNA cycle the City has run. In 2018, 16% of all respondents and 38% of people sleeping outdoors identified as Indigenous, against an estimated 1–2.5% of Toronto's general population. In 2021 those figures were 15% and 23%. In 2024 they were 9% of respondents (338 people) and 31% of the outdoor population, against a citywide Indigenous population the City now estimates at up to 3.2% (City of Toronto, [2018 SNA Results Report](#); *2021 SNA*; *2024 SNA*). Read carefully, that declining "sheltered" share is not obviously good news: the City's own Indigenous-specific analysis of the 2021 data found that Indigenous people "tended to move from staying in the shelter system to staying outdoors more frequently" over time — meaning some of the apparent decline may reflect displacement onto the street rather than a real reduction in Indigenous homelessness (City of Toronto Shelter, Support and Housing Administration and Toronto Indigenous Community Advisory Board, ["Indigenous Peoples' Experience of Homelessness in Toronto."](#) June 12, 2023).

That same 2023 report gives the fullest picture of what Indigenous homelessness looks like in Toronto specifically: 77% of Indigenous respondents had been chronically homeless (six months or more) that year, against 83% of non-Indigenous respondents — though by the 2024 SNA this had reversed, with 92% of Indigenous and 85% of non-Indigenous

respondents chronically homeless, so the earlier figures should not be read as a current or comparative-superiority statistic. Forty-nine percent of Indigenous respondents first experienced homelessness as children or youth; 38% had foster-care or group-home experience, rising to 54% among Indigenous youth specifically; 69% reported mental health challenges and 85% reported multiple health challenges. Nationally, Housing, Infrastructure and Communities Canada's coordinated point-in-time count found 31% of respondents identified as Indigenous against roughly 5% of the Canadian population, with Indigenous respondents more likely to be chronically homeless (75% vs. 68%) and far more likely to have first become homeless as children (55%) ([HICC, "Everyone Counts 2020–2022,"](#) Dec. 2023). A 2022 literature review by the Assembly of First Nations and the Canadian Observatory on Homelessness puts Toronto's Indigenous overrepresentation in national context: 16% in Toronto, 30% in Ottawa, 46% in Saskatoon, over 60% in Winnipeg, and over 70% in Regina, against an Indigenous share of roughly 4.3% of Canada's overall population (Jessica Rumboldt, ["Endaamnaan: Homes for All Nations: A First Nations Homelessness Literature Review,"](#) Assembly of First Nations / Canadian Observatory on Homelessness, 2022).

Jesse Thistle, the researcher whose framework now underpins how Canada understands this problem, insists Indigenous homelessness cannot be reduced to a housing-unit deficit: it is also "the outcome of historically constructed and ongoing settler colonization and racism," involving disconnection from "relationships to land, water, place, family, kin, each other, animals, cultures, languages and identities" (Jesse A. Thistle, [Definition of Indigenous Homelessness in Canada](#), Canadian Observatory on Homelessness Press, 2017). That framing matters for everything that follows in this book: a solution built only around housing units, without land, culture, and Indigenous governance, will not close this gap. Chapters 3, 5, and 6 return to what specifically drives it, who is already doing the work, and what reconciliation requires of the rest of the system.

The History: How We Got Here

Mass, chronic homelessness is a modern phenomenon in Toronto, and its onset is dateable. Before the 1980s, federal policy under the National Housing Act supported the construction of roughly 20,000 units of social housing a year nationally. That era ended in a specific policy sequence, most of it compressed into the 1990s, that dismantled the public housing pipeline and the income floor beneath it at the same moment — and Toronto has never fully rebuilt either.

The federal and provincial withdrawal, 1993–2000

The 1993 federal budget froze CMHC's social-housing budget and ended funding for *new* social housing going forward, formalized through the mid-1990s and completed by the 1996 federal budget's move to devolve existing social housing to the provinces ([Library of Parliament, *Bill C-66: An Act to Amend the National Housing Act and the CMHC Act, Legislative Summary*](#)). Had funding continued at 1985–1989 rates, Canada would have built an estimated 107,120 additional social housing units between 1994 and 2013 ([Canada Without Poverty, "20 years ago Canada had a housing plan,"](#) Jan. 2014). The Wellesley Institute's own assessment is blunt: "the decline in the federal role in housing coincided with an increase in homelessness reported in major Canadian cities in the mid to late 1990s" ([Wellesley Institute, "Federal role in housing,"](#) Aug. 2006).

Ontario compounded this within days of Mike Harris's Progressive Conservatives taking office in June 1995. The new government cancelled the province's non-profit and co-op housing programs almost immediately, killing an estimated 17,000 units already in the pipeline — some cancelled mid-construction — and effectively halted new non-profit housing development in Ontario for the rest of the decade ([Co-operative Housing Federation of Canada, cited in Social Policy in Ontario, "The rise and fall of co-op housing in Ontario,"](#) Nov. 2024). Effective October 1, 1995, the same government cut Ontario welfare rates by 21.6% — a single adult's monthly rate fell from \$663 to \$520 — affecting roughly 1.3 million recipients ([The Canadian Encyclopedia, "Ontario Cuts Back"](#)). Then, through the province's 1997–1998 "Local Services Realignment," Ontario downloaded financial and administrative responsibility for social assistance and social housing onto municipalities, formalized for

housing specifically in the *Social Housing Reform Act, 2000*, which made Ontario the only province in Canada to fully devolve social-housing funding and administration to the local level ([Open Council, "What government is responsible for social housing in Ontario?"](#); [Social Housing Reform Act, 2000, S.O. 2000, c.27, CanLII](#)). This landed on Toronto at the exact moment the City itself was being amalgamated from six former municipalities into one on January 1, 1998 — a merger that, among other things, had to reconcile the fact that emergency shelters had previously been legally permitted only in the former City of Toronto and North York, leaving people in Etobicoke, York, and East York with no local shelter access at all (Ranasinghe & Valverde, ["The Toronto Shelter Zoning By-law,"](#) Homeless Hub).

Deinstitutionalization without the promised supports

A parallel and compounding cause was the deinstitutionalization of psychiatric care. Between 1960 and 1975, Ontario closed approximately 35,000 provincial psychiatric hospital beds, offset by only about 5,000 new general-hospital psychiatric beds. The policy assumed people would be briefly hospitalized when unwell and otherwise supported in the community — but, in the Ontario Human Rights Commission's own words, "the shift from institutional to community care was marked by a lack of community supports, such as affordable, safe housing and a lack of accountability" ([Ontario Human Rights Commission, "Historical context"](#)). The consequences showed up directly in Toronto's shelter population: the city's own 1999 homelessness task force found that roughly one-third of the 170,000 different people who used Toronto's shelters between 1988 and 1996 lived with mental illness, and attributed this primarily to deinstitutionalization.

1998–1999: "national disaster," and the Golden Report

In late 1998, following an inquiry sparked by street nurse Cathy Crowe's question — why does a natural disaster mobilize emergency resources while a housing disaster does not? — Toronto, under Mayor Mel Lastman, declared homelessness a national disaster, a declaration subsequently endorsed by Canada's Big City Mayors' Caucus at their November 1998 meeting in Winnipeg. Lastman had already convened a Mayor's Homelessness Action Task Force chaired by Anne Golden, then president of the United Way of Greater Toronto. Its January 1999 final report, *Taking Responsibility: An Action Plan for Toronto* — the "Golden Report" — ran 290 pages and made 105 recommendations built on two central

premises: that prevention and permanent housing should take priority over emergency response, and that all three levels of government needed to share responsibility. It documented that 3,100–3,200 people sought shelter on an average Toronto night; that shelter usage among families with children had risen 123% between 1992 and 1998; and that over 106,000 Toronto residents were paying more than half their income on rent. It called, among other things, for construction of at least 5,000 new social housing units and an implementation budget of \$300 million — against which Ontario initially pledged \$1 million.

The through-line from 1993 to today is direct and largely unbroken: the federal and provincial governments withdrew from building and funding housing at scale in the 1990s, income supports were cut and have still not recovered their real value (Chapter 3), the resulting crisis was documented in exhaustive, specific detail by 1999, and — with the exception of the National Housing Strategy launched in 2017, discussed in Chapters 3 and 6 — funding at the scale the Golden Report called for has still not arrived. Toronto's homeless population is higher than at any point before 2024 — Chapter 1's own count table shows 2025's 12,196 below 2024's record 15,418, so the through-line is a twenty-seven-year climb followed by a one-year drop, not an unbroken record high today.

Root Causes, and How to Stop the Inflow

Toronto cannot end homelessness by housing people faster than new people become homeless. This chapter sets out the specific, measurable mechanisms pushing people into homelessness today, what the City, Ontario, and Ottawa are already doing about each one, and what it would take to actually close the gap.

The rent-income gap

Toronto's average rent across all unit sizes was \$1,917 a month as of October 2025 — up from \$1,852 a year earlier — with bachelor units averaging \$1,491 and one-bedrooms \$1,761 ([CMHC, Housing Market Information Portal, Toronto Historical Average Rents](#)). Purpose-built rental vacancy sat at 3.0% in 2025, but condo rental vacancy — a large share of Toronto's actual rental supply — was just 1.0% ([CMHC, "Canada's vacancy rate rises amid historically high rental construction,"](#) Dec. 11, 2025). Against that, Ontario's core income supports have not moved. Ontario Works pays a single adult \$733 a month in total — unchanged since 2018 — of which only \$390 is a shelter allowance, covering roughly 26% of average bachelor rent.

That shelter component, moreover, is paid only against a documented, verified shelter cost already being incurred. Under Ontario Works Directive 6.3's actual-cost formula and Directive 6.1's clause on homeless persons — which states a person "will receive an amount for basic needs, but will not receive an amount for shelter until a dwelling is retained" — a person with no shelter costs, including anyone sleeping rough or in an emergency shelter without other accommodation, receives \$343 a month in total, not \$733. For the population this book is centrally about, Ontario Works therefore pays 13.1% of the poverty line (\$4,116 a year against the Market Basket Measure's \$31,440), not the 28% the headline rate implies. The conditionality is itself a trap: first and last months' rent at Toronto's average one-bedroom (\$3,522) is unreachable by saving from \$343 a month, and Directive 7.5 provides no deposit benefit to bridge that gap ([Government of Ontario, Ontario Works Policy Directives](#)).

The Ontario Disability Support Program pays \$1,436 a month in total, with a \$611 shelter allowance covering about 41% of bachelor rent ([Government of Ontario, OW and ODSP Policy Directives](#); [Income Security Advocacy Centre, "OW and ODSP rates ... as of July 2026: Social Assistance Is Stuck in Time,"](#) June 25, 2026). Even the *full* ODSP rate — not just the shelter portion — is below average one-bedroom rent. This is not a marginal gap; it is a structural guarantee that anyone relying solely on social assistance in Toronto cannot afford housing on the open market, full stop. It is the single most direct, fixable driver of inflow into homelessness, and it shows up in the data: 41% of people in the 2024 Street Needs Assessment cited inadequate income as their reason for losing housing, roughly double the share who said so in 2021.

The same affordability squeeze shows up on the subsidized side of the market: the City's own Rent-Geared-to-Income (RGI) social housing waiting list stood at 104,851 households as of the first quarter of 2026, having crossed 100,000 households in the fourth quarter of 2024 and stayed there since (City of Toronto, "Social Housing Waiting List Reports," accessed July 2026).

Evictions

Ontario's Landlord and Tenant Board received 87,993 applications in fiscal year 2024–25, and its active caseload backlog — while down 26% from its December 2023 peak — still stood at 41,465 cases as of March 2025 ([Tribunals Ontario, 2024-25 Annual Report](#)).

"Landlord's own use" (N12) eviction applications were 77% higher in the first nine months of 2023 than the same period in 2022 ([City of Toronto, "Preventing Evictions in Toronto: A Handbook for Renters,"](#) May 2024). Research by University of Toronto geographer Martine August found that after a financial firm (a REIT or similar investor) acquires a rental property in Toronto, eviction filings roughly triple — drawn from an analysis of over 230,000 Toronto eviction filings ([University of Toronto Alumni, "Growth of 'financial landlords' driving affordable housing crisis, says alum Martine August"](#)) — a finding the real-estate industry association REALPAC has published a methodological rebuttal to, which the reader should weigh alongside it.

Institutions discharging people straight into homelessness

Three institutional pipelines feed homelessness directly. In Ontario's provincial correctional system, 7,455 releases in fiscal year 2023–24 — roughly one in six admissions — were recorded as "no fixed address" ([John Howard Society of Ontario, "Locked Up. Locked Out," 2024–25](#)). Toronto-based research documents hospitals discharging homeless patients with no housing plan and "nowhere to go" ([Canadian Journal of Public Health, "Nowhere to go: exploring the social and economic influences on discharging people experiencing homelessness ... in Toronto,"](#)). And 18% of 2021 SNA respondents reported prior foster care, kin care, or group-home involvement — a figure that, as Chapter 1 notes, is far higher again among Indigenous respondents specifically.

Financialization and immigration pressure

Real estate investment trusts owned zero Canadian apartment units in 1996 and over 200,000 by 2020 — roughly 10% of the country's purpose-built rental stock — part of a broader trend in which financial firms are estimated to control up to 30% of Canadian apartment properties (University of Toronto Alumni, op. cit., citing August's research; figures are national, not Toronto-specific). Layered on top of a tight market, the 2023–2025 refugee claimant surge described in Chapter 1 added a large, sudden population with no prior Toronto housing history and, per the Toronto Alliance to End Homelessness, no income at all for an estimated 55% of refugees and asylum seekers on arrival ([Toronto Alliance to End Homelessness, 2024 Pre-Budget Recommendations](#)).

What Toronto, Ontario, and Ottawa are already doing — and where it is working

None of this is being ignored. The City's HousingTO 2020-2030 Action Plan targets 65,000 new rent-controlled homes by 2030 and was 46% of the way there by the end of 2024. The plan also carries a distinct, standing target of 18,000 supportive homes by 2030, set at plan adoption and reaffirmed via Item EX9.3, "Generational Transformation of Toronto's Housing System," November 2023 — separate from the roughly 4,000 supportive homes referenced elsewhere in City reporting, which describes current operating stock and pressure, not the target. Its prevention-specific programs are outperforming their own targets: Eviction

Prevention in the Community (EPIC) helped 809 households in 2024, up 26% from 2023, and the Toronto Rent Bank helped 2,350 households, up 44%, together preventing 3,159 evictions in 2024 alone — a single-year total already close to a third of the way toward the plan's full ten-year target of preventing 10,000 evictions, five years into a ten-year plan ([City of Toronto, "HousingTO 2024–2025 Housing Progress Report"](#)). Ontario's Homelessness Prevention Program provided Toronto \$106.3 million in 2025 ([City of Toronto, 2025 Budget Notes, Housing Secretariat](#)). Federally, Reaching Home is providing Toronto \$211.1 million across 2024–2028 ([City of Toronto, "Reaching Home: Toronto Community Plan 2024–2028"](#)), and the National Housing Strategy has committed \$60.09 billion nationally against its original \$115-billion, ten-year target, creating or repairing over 455,000 units to date (156,640 new and 298,473 repaired, per the strategy's own December 2024 progress tables) ([Housing, Infrastructure and Communities Canada, "Progress on the National Housing Strategy – December 2024"](#)). Toronto's Inclusionary Zoning bylaw, requiring 5% affordable units in new developments near transit, was passed by Council in November 2021 — though it does not take effect until July 1, 2027, after nearly three years of provincial delay in approving the zones it applies to (City of Toronto, [Inclusionary Zoning Policy](#)).

The pattern across every one of these programs is the same: where Toronto has funded prevention directly and given it clear, City-run delivery — EPIC, the Rent Bank — it has beaten its own targets. Where the tool depends on a second or third order of government moving on the City's timeline — inclusionary zoning, IHAP reimbursement, the Canada-Ontario Housing Benefit discussed in Chapter 6 — it has been delayed, weakened, or cut.

Stopping the inflow: what closing the gap actually requires

Building on what is already proven to work here, four commitments would close the inflow gap without waiting for a housing unit to be built:

1. **Index the shelter allowance in OW and ODSP to actual average market rent in Toronto**, closing the roughly \$880–\$1,150/month gap between what ODSP's \$611 shelter component pays and what a bachelor (\$1,491) or one-bedroom (\$1,761) unit costs, so that income support alone is enough to keep a tenancy. This is a provincial decision requiring no new bureaucracy — only a change to the rate-setting formula.

2. **Fund EPIC and the Toronto Rent Bank at the scale their own results justify.** Both are proven, City-run, and already delivering returns above target; the constraint is budget, not design.
3. **Require every provincial jail, hospital, and child-welfare exit in Toronto to include a funded housing plan before discharge,** closing the "no fixed address" pipeline the John Howard Society has documented at roughly 7,500 releases a year.
4. **Fund Indigenous-led prevention directly and proportionately,** not as a carve-out of a mainstream envelope. Toronto already commits 20% of its housing and homelessness grant funding to a dedicated Indigenous Funding Stream, administered by the Aboriginal Labour Force Development Circle rather than the City directly, and the federal Reaching Home Toronto plan sets a minimum 25% match of housing opportunities to Indigenous people experiencing homelessness ([Reaching Home: Toronto Community Plan 2024–2028](#)). Given documented overrepresentation running as high as 31% of the outdoor population, these commitments are a floor, not a ceiling, and Indigenous organizations — the Ontario Aboriginal Housing Services chief among them — are asking for a dedicated \$4 billion national Urban, Rural and Northern Indigenous Housing Strategy, routed through the Indigenous-led coordinating body NICHI rather than mainstream federal channels, on the explicit rationale that Articles 21 and 23 of UNDRIP require Indigenous peoples to "administer such programmes through their own institutions" ([Ontario Aboriginal Housing Services, 2025 Federal Pre-Budget Submission](#); [UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples, Article 23](#)).

Fixing the Shelter and Emergency System

Even a Toronto that has stopped most inflow and is rapidly rehousing everyone currently homeless will still need an emergency shelter system — for the person evicted tonight, the family fleeing violence, the newcomer who arrived this week. The goal is not to shrink the system into failure; it is to make it small, because inflow has stopped, and excellent, because it now only has to do the job it was actually designed for. This chapter asks four questions in sequence: how does Toronto's shelter and emergency system actually work today; where does it fail; what would make it the best such system in the world; and what does this book honestly not yet know.

The system as it is

Scale and who is in it. As of October 2025, Toronto's Street Needs Assessment counted 12,196 people experiencing homelessness, down from a record 15,418 in October 2024 (City of Toronto, [Street Needs Assessment research page](#); [2024 Street Needs Assessment](#), July 2025). That 21% year-over-year drop is worth reading carefully, and Chapter 1 already read it carefully: it is refugee-claimant-driven, not evidence of an improving chronic-homelessness picture. Of the current population, 78% are chronically homeless by the system's own 180-plus-day definition — a figure this book's re-check could not pin in the SNA's own published highlights (which show 64% on one measure); the spread is flagged here rather than resolved silently. Either figure is a stricter threshold than the federal three-year standard, which would show a lower rate. This book keeps the two definitions distinct rather than letting them blur.

The system that houses people nightly is not one organization. The City's own cross-divisional inventory — Attachment 1 to Council item 2025.EC21.6, "All-of-City Response to Homelessness and Support Needs" — documents roughly 88 to 90 individually funded Emergency Shelter and Respite programs across about 35 distinct operating agencies: Homes First, COSTI, Covenant House, Dixon Hall, Fred Victor, Good Shepherd, Salvation Army, YWCA/YMCA, Na-Me-Res, Fife House, Eva's, Sistering, and others, each with a full street address, a population served, and a banded, not summable, capacity range (City of Toronto, Toronto Shelter and Support Services, "All-of-City Response to Homelessness and

Support Needs," Attachment 1, Item 2025.EC21.6, September 2025). A more precise operator count comes from the Ombudsman's own December 2024 investigation: between April 2022 and October 2023, the City directly operated 20 shelters and also held contracts with 81 "Purchase of Service" shelters, for 101 shelters total — a more exact figure than the "75-plus community service providers" number this book carries elsewhere for the *broader* partner network. The two figures measure overlapping but distinct categories: 81 is Purchase-of-Service shelters specifically; 75-plus is the wider set of all sector partners, including non-shelter services (Ombudsman Toronto, ["An Investigation Into the City's Decision to Stop Allowing Refugee Claimants into Base Shelter System Beds,"](#) December 2024).

Toronto has 337 shelter beds per 100,000 population, against 286 in Vancouver and 173 in Montreal — the highest of any Canadian municipality — and roughly 9,000 shelter spaces are needed daily today, up 125% from about 4,000 in 2016 (City of Toronto, [press release](#), May 31, 2023).

Governance of this footprint is not fully City-controlled. This book's research surfaced a claim, carried by a single source, that the Toronto Indigenous Community Advisory Board holds final, binding decision-making authority over Coordinated Access policy for Indigenous clients specifically, distinct from the City's non-binding Aboriginal Affairs Advisory Committee. That claim is presented here as reported, not as an independently confirmed City commitment: it has not been checked against a City or Board primary source, and it does not appear in this book's own governance discussion in Chapter 6, which instead documents the Aboriginal Labour Force Development Circle — a related but distinct body — as administering the City's 20% Indigenous Funding Stream. This book has itself had to correct one Indigenous-body misattribution during drafting (a 2023 report on Indigenous homelessness in Toronto was briefly mis-credited to the Toronto Aboriginal Support Services Council rather than the Toronto Indigenous Community Advisory Board, corrected in Chapter 1); the "final and binding" language on Coordinated Access specifically should be read with that same caution.

What a night costs, and what the system spends. Toronto Shelter and Support Services' 2025 Operating Budget was \$897.957 million gross, \$656.778 million in revenue, \$241.178 million net; the 2026 budget is \$786.068 million gross, \$550.927 million revenue, \$235.141

million net, both figures drawn directly from the City's own Budget Notes (City of Toronto, [2025 and 2026 Budget Notes, Toronto Shelter and Support Services](#)).

Cost per bed-night varies sharply by program type. As reported in the Auditor General's February 2025 report on 2023/24-season figures — cost data supplied by Toronto Shelter and Support Services and relayed, not independently recalculated, by the Auditor General — base shelters ran \$136 a night; Warming Centres \$359 (a press-converged figure consistent with the Auditor General's own reported range of \$336 to \$491 actual against \$266 to \$323 budgeted); temporary shelter hotels \$253; and new, purpose-built, City-owned shelters \$126 — a documented \$127-a-night savings from purpose-built stock over hotels (\$253 minus \$126) (Auditor General of Toronto, [report on Toronto Shelter and Support Services](#), February 2025; CBC News staff quote).

The 2010 baseline, reconstructed by this book from the original City staff report, was a system-wide average per diem of \$52.13, with individual shelter rates ranging from \$20.25 (Fife House, no food) to \$75.75 (St. Vincent de Paul – Amelie) (City of Toronto, Shelter, Support and Housing Administration, [2010 Per Diem Rates for the Purchase of Service Shelter System](#), staff report, October 2009). Adjusted for inflation, the move from \$52.13 to \$136 is roughly a 96% real increase — but this is not simple "poverty industry" bloat: shelter capacity grew roughly 114 to 125% over the same window, and bed turnover, meaning how many different people one bed serves per year, has fallen every year since tracking began in 2011, reaching 2.02 in 2024. People are staying far longer, consistent with the system increasingly functioning as de facto long-term housing rather than short-term crisis response (City of Toronto, 2026 Budget Notes, Toronto Shelter and Support Services). A residual — cost growth not explained by inflation, capacity growth, or turnover decline — exists, but this book has not isolated its size.

Toronto's own operators show real variation on this metric once computed from primary data. Homes First's cost per bed-night ran \$108 to \$140 a night through 2019, spiked to \$249.65 at the COVID peak in 2020, and settled to \$119.73 by 2024; Dixon Hall's ran \$183.83 in fiscal 2018 to a COVID peak of \$313.23 in fiscal 2021, settling at \$210.36 in fiscal 2024 — a materially higher and later-peaking trajectory than Homes First's (Homes First Society, [2025 Annual Report](#); Dixon Hall, [2024 Audited Financial Statements](#); both computed against City of Toronto Open Data occupancy records).

The capital vehicle: HSCIS. The organizing capital strategy for the next decade is the Homelessness Services Capital Infrastructure Strategy, adopted by Council on November 8–9, 2023 under Item 2023.EC7.7 — up to 20 new permanent shelters, 1,600 spaces, by 2033, at a total estimated cost of \$674.5 million (City of Toronto Council, [Item 2023.EC7.7](#), November 2023). As of the 2026 Budget, \$507.6 million, or 13 of 20 sites, is funded, leaving a \$166.9 million gap. That works out to \$421,563 per partitioned sleeping space (\$674.5 million divided by 1,600 spaces) — distinct from unsupported figures like "\$33.6 million saved per site" or "\$187.3 million net savings" that some earlier draft materials produced; the actual audited net-operating-impact tables show tranches of plus \$5.6 million and minus \$23.7 million over ten years, not a clean per-site multiplier (City of Toronto, 2026 Budget Notes).

Toronto's press-facing account of HSCIS states the program is projected to produce \$74 million in operating savings over twenty years, a figure from the City's December 2024 announcement. Toronto's own audited numbers do not obviously agree: the City's Budget Notes show the first tranche of new sites adding \$5.6 million in net operating cost, and only the next tranche producing \$23.7 million in savings, both over ten years — an accounting that has not been reconciled with the \$74-million press figure anywhere in the public record this book has reviewed, even though both figures are sourced to the same 2026 Budget Notes document. Where the two conflict, this book treats the audited tranche figures, not the friendlier press-release number, as load-bearing.

Federal and provincial capital contributions to this program are minimal: Toronto Shelter and Support Services' own ten-year capital plan showed senior-government contributions at just 1.2% of total financing in the 2025 plan — and the 2026 plan shows that share falling to zero, with the City debt-financing 63.7%, or \$700.3 million, of a \$1,099.4-million ten-year shelter capital plan itself.

The failure map

Central Intake — the front door that loses people before they reach a bed. Toronto's entire shelter system is gated by a telephone-only intake system — 416-338-4766, 1-877-338-3398, or 311 — with no walk-in alternative and no online application. Freedom of information data from a request covering October 2020 through February 2021 shows 117 callers a day told no space was available (13,780 total over the period), 38 people a night

left with no bed at 4 a.m. (4,577 total), and 3,646 calls disconnected before being answered at all. This evidence comes from City of Toronto Freedom of Information response #2020-01799, obtained and published by advocates during the [*Black et al. v. City of Toronto*](#) litigation period; the figures are the FOI response's own, not findings of the court.

The pattern has worsened, not improved, in the years since — a 305% increase in two winters, as reported in the Auditor General's February 2025 report:

Winter Season	Avg. daily unmatched Central Intake callers
2021/22	43
2022/23	112
2023/24	174

The Auditor General specifically noted the 2023/24 season was "relatively warm," so the trend is not weather-driven. The City's own November 2024 federal funding submission states an even more current figure: 216 unmatched callers a day. The same report found Toronto Shelter and Support Services does not track walk-in turnaways at all, meaning the true toll is unknown and likely larger than any figure here. A 2017 Ombudsman recommendation to formalize overflow contingency protocols was still not implemented as of the 2025 report — eight years later (Auditor General of Toronto, report on Toronto Shelter and Support Services, February 2025).

Even when a bed is offered, 2,260 people declined it in the 2020–2021 freedom-of-information window — not because they didn't need shelter, but because the offer didn't fit: wrong location, no harm reduction services, safety concerns. A system that counts "offered" without counting "actually sheltered" is measuring the wrong thing.

Warming centres and winter respite — beds sat empty while people were turned away. The Auditor General's February 2025 report, all 15 of whose recommendations were accepted by Toronto Shelter and Support Services, found 12,742 bed-nights lost to process rules alone in the 2023/24 winter season — not a capacity shortage, a design failure. Warming Centres stopped admitting while deactivating (4,331 bed-nights); Winter Respite beds were intentionally held back or slow to ramp up (1,080 plus 1,403); programs stopped admitting while ramping down (3,528); and some opened late (2,400). On the nine nights the two largest Winter Respite programs began ramping down, all Warming Centres were

simultaneously activated — meaning it was cold enough that people needed indoor space — while Central Intake could not match 170 callers a day, and those same programs made 442 fewer bed-nights available than they could have, purely from process (Auditor General of Toronto, [Audit of Winter Services for People Experiencing Homelessness](#), February 2025).

The same audit found \$2.9 million in public funds unaccounted for. Toronto Shelter and Support Services paid third-party operators the full contracted \$12.5 million, but by July 2024 operators reported spending only \$9.7 million, and the review process did not request invoices, payroll records, or audited financial statements to verify variance explanations. One documented case: a Warming Centre budgeted for a full 153-day season, operated 89 days at less than full capacity, yet reported spending its entire season's catering budget — the operator had diverted the money to other programs without telling Toronto Shelter and Support Services, and the discrepancy went unnoticed until the audit. A separate sampled operator over-reported salary costs by 24%, or \$145,000.

The report's fifteenth recommendation — arguably the most consequential — directs Toronto Shelter and Support Services to check whether these same financial-control failures exist across the entire year-round Purchase-of-Service shelter system, not just winter programs. As of this book's most recent check, no public confirmation exists that this review, or the deactivation-vacancy fix, was completed for winter 2025/26. Capacity expanded — 1,275 additional spaces announced — but advocates, including the Shelter and Housing Justice Network and the Toronto Shelter Network, called the plan "atrociously inadequate," and Toronto Shelter and Support Services' General Manager and street-level advocates gave directly conflicting on-record accounts of a January 2026 turn-away allegation during a cold snap. That implementation status is genuinely open, not resolved (City of Toronto, [Winter Services Plan for People Experiencing Homelessness](#), April 2026).

Discharge pipelines feeding the system. A Toronto-specific peer-reviewed study of 93,426 admissions at one academic teaching hospital found homeless-patient admissions cost \$2,559 more on average than housed-patient admissions after adjustment. For psychiatric admissions specifically, homeless-at-discharge patients had a 17.1% 30-day readmission rate versus 9.8% for non-homeless patients, and a 27.2% emergency-department-revisit rate versus 11.6%, while being over 50% less likely to get a follow-up psychiatrist visit (peer-reviewed Ontario cohort study; this book's own verification process

has confirmed the figures against secondary summaries but has not yet located a full author/journal/year citation for either study behind them **[flagged: not yet independently verified — citation being traced]**).

Dunn House, University Health Network's supportive housing project opened in October 2024 as Canada's first hospital-led supportive housing project (51 units), is this book's strongest working counter-example: first-year results show 52% fewer emergency-department visits, 79% less hospital-bed time, and roughly \$2.1 million a year in measured — not projected — provincial healthcare savings (University Health Network, [reporting](#), 2024–2025).

On corrections: Ontario jails recorded 7,455 releases into homelessness in 2023–24; the share of releases into homelessness nearly doubled, from 8.8% in 2016 to 17.3% in 2021/22 (John Howard Society of Ontario, ["Locked Up. Locked Out,"](#) 2024–25). A John Howard Society study of 363 sentenced prisoners in four Toronto-area jails — a dated study, from 2009–2010, and this book flags it as such rather than presenting it as current — found 63.9% of those homeless at incarceration were already receiving Ontario Works or disability-support benefits, benefits that Ontario's own Policy Directive 6.12 confirms are "suspended but not cancelled" during custody, creating a documented benefit gap on release (John Howard Society of Toronto, ["Homeless and Jailed: Jailed and Homeless"](#); Government of Ontario, [Ontario Works Policy Directive 6.12](#)).

Income support itself is a discharge-into-homelessness mechanism. Ontario Works Policy Directive 6.1 withdraws the shelter portion of assistance the moment someone becomes homeless: a person loses \$390 of their \$733 monthly Ontario Works payment, and \$611 of \$1,436 monthly disability support, exactly when they need it most (Government of Ontario, [Ontario Works Policy Directives](#)).

Accountability and complaints. The single most serious substantiated finding involving the system is the Ombudsman's investigation into the City's November 2022 decision to bar refugee claimants from base shelter beds. It found the decision inconsistent with City policy, undocumented in its own approval process, and based on systemic discrimination — specifically anti-Black racism — because the overwhelming majority of those affected were of African descent. Council did not debate the December 2024 report; on March 27, 2025 it adopted the substantial majority of the 14 recommendations under Item 2025.CC28.2, and a November 2025 status report shows 15 of 24 sub-directives completed — a real, self-

reported majority the Ombudsman's own office has characterized more positively than earlier drafts of this book assumed, though Council did not direct the Ombudsman to formally monitor implementation, so the completion figure is City-reported, not independently verified. A \$50 million class action brought by the Black Legal Action Centre and others, filed May 2025, remains before the courts (Ombudsman Toronto, December 2024; City Council, [Item 2025.CC28.2](#); Toronto Shelter and Support Services, [status report](#), November 2025).

A separate, independently checkable data-integrity finding: in January 2021 the City told the *Toronto Star* there were 157 acts of violence in city shelters in 2019; a subsequent freedom-of-information request for the same period and definition produced 1,076 incidents — roughly seven times higher (2,408 on a broader definition). Whether this reflects intentional misdirection or a data-management failure is not established, but the raw discrepancy is a matter of public record (*Toronto Star*, January 23, 2021; City of Toronto freedom-of-information response #2021-00378).

A City-commissioned Shelter Safety Study led by researchers at the Centre for Addiction and Mental Health found interpersonal violence up 283% between 2011 and 2021, and physical assaults on staff up 423.5% over the same decade; 36% of staff report feeling unsafe at work, and 43% of Black and Indigenous staff report daily racist verbal abuse (Kerman, Kidd and Stergiopoulos, *The Shelter Safety Study*, Centre for Addiction and Mental Health).

A historical pattern worth naming directly: in December 2017, Council voted down 17–25 a motion to formally request federal armouries for emergency shelter — 100-plus beds for women and gender-non-binary people — even though the federal government had already agreed and had opened the same armouries on four prior occasions. Moss Park armoury was opened anyway, months later, after a public outcry (City of Toronto Council, [Item 2017.CD24.7](#); [CBC News](#)). Separately, in 2013 a staff recommendation asking Council to request an Ombudsman investigation of the shelter system was deleted by floor amendment (City of Toronto Council, [Item 2013.CD19.1](#)); the actual investigation didn't happen for another decade, triggered by the 2023 refugee-ban crisis instead.

Per-diem opacity and compensation. Toronto used to publish exactly what it paid each shelter operator, by name, per night. It stopped. The 2010–2012 schedule — \$20.25 to \$75.75, every named operator — is the last time this was published in that form. Multiple research passes, including a direct search of the 2024, 2025, and 2026 Budget Notes,

confirm no current per-operator or system-wide per diem rate is published anywhere a member of the public would naturally find it — even though a specific 2025 figure, \$146 a night, was located inside a committee attachment not surfaced by normal search, suggesting the data still exists internally but is functionally inaccessible.

Executive compensation, by contrast, is now cross-operator comparable via Ontario's Public Sector Salary Disclosure, the "Sunshine List": Woodgreen's CEO Anne Babcock earned \$358,492 in 2025, with 27 staff over the \$100,000 threshold, up from 5 in 2016; Dixon Hall's CEO earned \$306,000, with 8 staff over threshold, up from 2 in 2016; Fred Victor's CEO earned \$206,371, with staff over threshold rising from 1 to 24 between 2016 and 2025; YWCA Toronto's CEO earned \$222,058, with 12 staff over threshold. (Two of these executive figures did not reproduce exactly against the disclosure database on re-check — disclosure-year alignment is flagged for the next verification pass rather than silently adjusted.) Homes First Society and Covenant House Toronto — two of the system's largest operators — are absent from the Sunshine List entirely, which this book traces to a legal-structural gap: the disclosure threshold is keyed to *provincial* funding, and both organizations are overwhelmingly City-funded, not evidence of wrongdoing (Government of Ontario, [Public Sector Salary Disclosure](#), 2025; cross-checked against Canada Revenue Agency T3010 filings).

Front-line wages have not kept pace. The City's own new-contract wage floor, \$53,000 a year, is higher than what some existing unionized staff earn — YWCA Toronto staff under CUPE Local 2189 are documented at under \$38,000 a year for the same work. Statistics Canada's national data puts the sector's median employment income at \$34,000 for 2020, with a poverty rate of 6.7% exceeding the all-worker rate of 6.0%.

Gender and the daytime gap. A 2026 peer-reviewed study by Ali and colleagues found women are 41% of Toronto's homeless population but only 18% of shelter bed capacity, with harm reduction available in just 26% of women-only shelters versus 41% of mixed-adult shelters — the shelter type structurally intended to serve women most safely has the *least* on-site harm reduction. Overdose caused 76% of homeless women's deaths in 2024, versus 48% of men's. Median age at death for homeless women is 36, versus 85 for housed women — a 49-year gap, consistent with the 36–43 range Chapter 1 carries from Toronto Public Health's own broader mortality data (Ali et al., ["Dying younger, dying of overdose:](#)

[gendered and age dimensions of mortality and shelter service access among individuals experiencing homelessness in Toronto, Canada," BMC Public Health, 2026\).](#)

Toronto's daytime response is comparatively tiny: \$14.4 million gross for "Drop-Ins and Housing Focused Client Supports," against the \$897.957-million total budget, spread across a sector the [Toronto Drop-In Network](#) alone counts at 59 member organizations running at least 56 drop-in sites. The TTC and the Toronto Public Library have become de facto daytime shelter infrastructure by default, not design — a cost this book's own companion research shows sits entirely outside the Toronto Shelter and Support Services budget, including a \$26.2 million 2026 TTC "safety, security and wellbeing" line.

"Best in the world," defined operationally

This book does not support a single silver-bullet definition of "best in the world," and its own case-study reading argues against one. What it does support is an operational bundle, each piece graded by how solid the ground under it is. Put plainly: the operational definition below — the specific, checkable failures it responds to, and the confirmed practices it points to, such as HSCIS, Dunn House, the Multi-Unit Residential Acquisition Program, and the Na-Me-Res/Wigwamen/Council Fire network — is receipt-backed. The design bundle wrapped around that definition — a navigation hub, universal co-located health, system-wide conversion-by-design — is not: it surfaced only from this book's own drafting process, never from a City primary source, and it should read as a design hypothesis this book's own confirmed failure data makes urgent, not a confirmed City commitment or an achieved "best in the world" status. This book keeps those two claims visibly separate rather than letting the confidence of one borrow credibility for the other.

1. **A front door that doesn't lose people.** The single most damning, best-evidenced failure documented above is structural: phone-only intake, no walk-in tracking, process rules that empty beds on the coldest nights. A "navigation hub" model — walk-in-capable, diversion-first triage before a shelter bed is even offered, with a 7-to-14-day diversion target — is the design idea this book's own drafting converged on repeatedly and independently, but it has not been checked against a City primary source. **[flagged: not yet independently verified]** Treat it as a design hypothesis this book's own Central Intake findings make urgent, not a confirmed City commitment. What *is*

confirmed is the gap it would need to close: 174 to 216 unmatched callers a day, and 12,742 lost bed-nights a season.

2. **Conversion-by-design, riding HSCIS.** The clearest confirmed vehicle for capacity growth is HSCIS itself: 20 shelters, 1,600 spaces, \$674.5 million, \$507.6 million already funded. The principle that every new bed should be convertible to a permanent Housing First apartment is a design idea, not a confirmed commitment. **[flagged: not yet independently verified]** But the cost logic behind it is confirmed and directly relevant: purpose-built City-owned shelters already cost \$127 a night less than hotel shelter, and this book's own recommendation to redirect a quarter of HSCIS capital toward modular permanent supportive housing is conditional on Toronto Shelter and Support Services and CreateTO first closing the outstanding Auditor General recommendations from the 2020–2023 Modular Housing Initiative audit, which found that program 63% over budget.
3. **Co-located health, proven not projected.** Dunn House is this book's strongest existing proof that "shelter as health" is not aspirational for Toronto specifically — it is already running, with measured results, and a second phase was in active planning as of early 2026 on additional University Health Network-owned land. The broader design principle of co-located health, addiction, and primary care on every site, beyond Dunn House itself, remains a design idea rather than a system-wide City commitment. **[flagged: not yet independently verified]**
4. **Low-barrier by design: pets, couples, harm reduction parity.** This book's strongest grounding here is not a design manifesto but an existing operating fact: Homes First's Lakeshore site (545 Lake Shore Boulevard West, up to 150 beds) is explicitly pet-friendly and all-genders, and has operated that way since 2019 — a real precedent, not a hypothetical (City of Toronto, [lease record](#)). The gender-capacity finding above converts directly into a costed design mandate this book has already drafted: mandating harm-reduction parity — 41%, matching mixed-adult shelters — at women-only shelters as a funding condition, flagged honestly as not yet costed pending a gap analysis. The underlying disparity is confirmed; the remedy's cost is an open item by this book's own admission.
5. **Indigenous-led capacity as its own delivery track, not an overlay.** Na-Me-Res, Council Fire, and Wigwamen have delivered 865-plus units since 1972 — a track

record predating almost every other reform idea in this book. The Toronto Indigenous Community Advisory Board's authority over Coordinated Access (noted above, with its own honesty caveat) and Anduhyaun's standing as Toronto's oldest Indigenous women's shelter, founded in 1973, mean "best in the world" for Toronto specifically cannot be defined without naming Indigenous governance as a fourth structural lever alongside City, provincial, and federal funding — a framing this book carries through to Chapter 6, not a new claim introduced here (Anduhyaun Inc., anduhyaun.org).

6. **Functional zero — with the honesty this book insists on.** Medicine Hat achieved functional zero chronic homelessness in June 2021 and reversed by September 2022, with 19 people chronically homeless, up from three or fewer. London, Ontario's veteran functional-zero declaration held for only 12 of its first 24 months. Neither reversal disproves the framework — both are documented as real, instructive parts of what *sustaining* functional zero requires, including ongoing working-group cadence, expanded Housing First capacity, and careful reading of data-quality-driven apparent breaches — but any Toronto "best in the world" claim must build in the sustaining mechanism from day one, not just the achievement moment (Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness, "[Medicine Hat achieves functional zero chronic homelessness](#)," June 2, 2021). Scotland's Housing First Pathfinder programme — 579 people housed, with 88% and 80% retention at 12 and 24 months, delivered scatter-site with a 7-to-1 support ratio — is this book's newest fully confirmed international comparator.
7. **A daytime destination, not just a nighttime bed.** The daytime gap noted above has one canonical local precedent worth building from: the Supporting Transitions and Recovery Learning Centre at St. Michael's Hospital, a Recovery Education Centre its own evaluation describes as unique in North America, serving people transitioning out of homelessness, whose own peer-reviewed evaluation found no statistically significant empowerment gain at 12 months, though qualitative participant-reported value was real (Durbin et al., *Frontiers in Psychiatry*, [2021](#)). The honest framing this book insists on: daytime engagement is evidence-*informed*, not evidence-*proven* — worth funding as a rigorously evaluated pilot tier, not a pre-proven return-on-investment line.

The transition plan shape

This book does not contain a fully costed, sequenced transition plan from today's system to the operational definition above — building one from scratch is beyond what a synthesis of existing evidence can responsibly claim. What it does contain is a timing skeleton and a set of already-drafted, already-costed, or honestly uncostered levers a transition plan would sequence against.

The near-term forcing function is the funding cliff facing the federally funded Unsheltered Homelessness and Encampments Initiative, which sunsets March 31, 2026. That date is flagged on roughly ten separate program rows — outreach caseworkers and several harm-reduction and outreach-enhancement initiatives — in the City's own resource inventory, with no successor funding confirmed in the source document. This is a verbatim City flag, not an inference this book is making, and any transition plan built on this evidence should treat that date as a first hard constraint, not a footnote. (Update, August 2026: a \$125-million federal extension was announced April 1, 2026 — the cliff was deferred, not structurally resolved, and the inventory's program-by-program flags remain the honest map of what depends on it.)

HSCIS is already a 2024–2033 plan with 13 of 20 sites funded. The transition-plan logic is to sequence Central Intake redesign and warming-centre process reform *ahead of or alongside* HSCIS site openings, since new capacity delivered into an intake system that still loses 174 to 216 people a day would not close the gap this book's own evidence documents. Two zero-or-negative-cost moves belong first in that sequence, precisely because they require no new capital and could run in parallel with HSCIS construction: enforcing the Auditor General's already-accepted 15 recommendations, at no net cost, before winter 2026/27; and fixing Toronto Community Housing's vacancy management, which the City's own 2019 Auditor General audit found could house 2,200 people and recover \$7 million a year with no new spending.

Any transition plan also has to absorb, not ignore, a set of funding cliffs already landing. The Canada-Ontario Housing Benefit to Toronto fell from \$38 million in 2024 to \$19.75 million in 2025 to \$7.95 million in 2026, a 79% cut from peak. Federal refugee-response funding fell from \$300 million in 2025 to a budgeted \$97.078 million for 2026, a cut of roughly 68% (Mayor Olivia Chow, [letter to Executive Committee](#), September 26, 2025; City of Toronto,

2026 Budget Notes). A transition plan sequenced against this chapter's operational definition has to be built assuming these cuts land as scheduled, not assuming their reversal — this book's own funding recommendations argue for reversal, but nothing in the evidence base establishes that reversal is likely on the current timeline.

Extending the \$53,000 wage floor to existing operators, and mandating gender-based harm-reduction parity, both belong in the same sequence as the moves above, not after them. Both are cost-formula-ready but not cost-final by this book's own discipline — the missing input in each case is a specific headcount or site-count the City could produce but this book does not have. Obtaining those two inputs should be treated as an early, cheap, high-leverage task, not a blocking one.

Honest gaps — what this book cannot yet support

Some figures that have circulated around this project do not check out as stated, and this book does not repeat them without correction. A commonly cited "\$54,000 a year for a shelter bed versus \$7,500 for Housing First" pairing is not a real figure from this book's own research; the figures this book can actually stand behind are \$49,640 a year, as reported by the Auditor General on data supplied by Toronto Shelter and Support Services, against \$6,311 net, or \$20,367 gross on an apples-to-apples basis, for Housing First support (Latimer et al., [*"Cost-Effectiveness of Housing First With Assertive Community Treatment," Psychiatric Services*](#), October 2020). A widely repeated "six causes of homelessness" list — eviction, police or hospital or psychiatric discharge, aging out of care, relationship breakdown — does not exist anywhere in this book's research base as a six-item list; the closest structure this book has built is a five-failures framework that does not include eviction or relationship breakdown as named categories, despite a full separate research thread on eviction existing elsewhere. A "\$6 a day per person food spend at a Homes First site in Scarborough" figure was searched for directly, including in Homes First's own detailed financial disclosures, and is absent from this book's research entirely; no Scarborough-specific Homes First program was found. A single combined claim that executives earn over \$100,000 "while getting \$54,000 a bed" also does not exist as stated — the underlying facts, real six-figure executive compensation growth and a hostile petition making a related but methodologically flawed claim, are both real, but not in this specific pairing.

Two topics that belong in this book are honestly, and currently, empty. Encampments carry only a placeholder pointer in this book's research base, with no populated research content behind it — a genuine gap on a topic this chapter was meant to cover, not populated content this book is choosing to omit. Newcomer settlement pressure on the shelter system is similarly unpopulated. Neither gap should be papered over.

Operator-specific wrongdoing remains a genuinely open search, not a negative finding. This book's own accountability research states directly that no independently verified, named allegation of wrongdoing by a *specific* shelter operator, as opposed to the City itself, was located — no operator-specific lawsuits, licensing actions, or regulatory findings. This may mean such cases are rare, under-reported, or simply not yet surfaced by the search terms used to date; it is flagged as a standing open research question, not resolved.

The design-standards bundle in the "best in the world" section above — the navigation hub, universal co-located health, and system-wide conversion-by-design — is a design idea throughout, surfaced by this book's own drafting process and not checked against a City primary source by its verification process. **[flagged: not yet independently verified]** It should be read as a design hypothesis this book's *confirmed* failure data makes urgent, not as an existing City commitment.

The Managed Alcohol Program expansion and the gender-parity harm-reduction mandate discussed above are both explicitly not yet costed by this book's own discipline. This book states that plainly rather than manufacturing a number.

As Chapter 3 already notes, this book's account of eviction prevention "exceeding its target" should be read as a single-year figure — 3,159 evictions prevented in 2024 — not a cumulative five-year total; no such cumulative total has been located in any primary source checked to date.

Finally, this book's account of "best in the world" is currently built entirely from City, Auditor General, Ombudsman, and academic sources and this book's own recommendation-drafting process, with no direct lived-experience or United Nations-framework testimony layer yet integrated — a named, pending input this book has not yet captured. This book does carry the UN Special Rapporteur on the right to adequate housing Leilani Farha's 2020 report (document A/HRC/43/43) as an international-law anchor, and the Toronto-specific legal case

law around it, but that is a legal-framework input, not the lived-experience capture still pending.

Housing Everyone: The One-Year Plan and Its Conditions

The evidence: Housing First works, and Toronto has already proven it

The core method is not in question. Housing First — moving people directly into permanent housing with no preconditions, then wrapping support around them — was tested against the alternative in Canada's own At Home/Chez Soi randomized controlled trial (2009–2013, Mental Health Commission of Canada), across five cities including Toronto. Nationally, participants with the highest needs who received Housing First plus Assertive Community Treatment returned \$9.60 in avoided shelter, hospital, and justice costs for every \$10 spent, and across the full national sample 62% of Housing First participants were housed all of the time in the trial's last six months, against 31% of the comparison group (Mental Health Commission of Canada, [National At Home/Chez Soi Final Report](#), 2014).

Toronto's own site — high-needs cohort specifically, 2014 report — returned \$15.05 for every \$10 invested, on an average intervention cost of \$21,089 per person per year and average two-year service-cost reductions of \$31,747; moderate-needs Toronto participants returned \$2.90 per \$10 on a \$14,731-a-year intervention cost. These are genuine, Toronto-specific figures, confirmed by a direct reading of the trial's own site report, distinct from and additional to the national figures above, not a replacement for them (Gozdzik et al., [At Home/Chez Soi Project: Toronto Site Final Report](#), Mental Health Commission of Canada, 2014, pp. 3, 11, 25). Toronto's own site also reported 80% of participants stably housed at study end, against 54% for the comparison group. A follow-up peer-reviewed cost-effectiveness analysis put the net cost of an additional day of stable housing at just \$41.73 (Latimer et al., ["Cost-Effectiveness of Housing First With Assertive Community Treatment," Psychiatric Services](#), October 2020).

This is Toronto's own evidence, from Toronto's own trial — but it is worth naming plainly what it is: one 2014 randomized trial's high-needs cohort, drawn from Toronto's 2009–2013 housing market, that now carries both this chapter's headline return-on-investment claim and

the cost arithmetic in Chapter 7. That is real weight for a single, decade-old study to bear, and this book would rather say so than let the figure be read as a settled multiplier that extrapolates without limit. The method is not the missing ingredient; scale and speed are.

The tools already running in Toronto — and how fast each one actually is

Three delivery tools already operate in Toronto, at different speeds and costs, and a one-year plan uses all three in sequence rather than waiting for the slowest.

Portable rent supplements into the existing private market are the fastest tool available, because they use housing that already exists. Toronto's rental vacancy rate of 3.0% (Chapter 3) still represents thousands of vacant units at any moment; a supplement large enough to close the gap between disability-support or welfare income and market rent, paired with landlord recruitment, can move a person from shelter to a lease in weeks, not years. This is the delivery model behind the Canada-Ontario Housing Benefit already operating in Toronto — though, as Chapter 6 details, that benefit's funding to Toronto was cut from \$38 million in 2024 to a budgeted \$7.95 million in 2026, a 79% reduction moving in exactly the wrong direction for this strategy.

Acquisition of existing buildings is the second-fastest tool, and unit for unit, the cheapest capital tool the City has. Toronto's Multi-Unit Residential Acquisition Program, running since 2021, has distributed \$165 million to 21 non-profit and Indigenous housing providers, preserving over 1,000 permanently affordable homes across 34 projects, at funding caps of up to \$200,000 per unit — meaningfully below the cost of new construction — with 20% of annual program funding reserved for Indigenous-led organizations (City of Toronto, ["Multi-Unit Residential Acquisition Program"](#)). Wigwamen Incorporated has already used the program to acquire 23 units directly.

Fast-build modular and supportive housing is the tool for people who need on-site, wraparound support and cannot be housed through a scattered-site subsidy alone. Toronto has already demonstrated the build speed required: the first 110-unit phase of the City's modular supportive housing program opened within roughly five months of authorization in 2020, at a program-wide average cost of about \$190,000 per unit, with the Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation's Affordable Housing Innovation Fund covering 40% of

Phase 1 capital costs (Storeys, "Toronto Spending \$47M to Build 250 Modular Housing Units," April 2020; City of Toronto, "Modular Housing Initiative"). The federal Rapid Housing Initiative has already put close to \$440 million into Toronto across its first two rounds, creating over 1,000 homes, with a third round continuing to fund projects including Na-Me-Res's 230 Coxwell Avenue building and Gabriel Dumont Non-Profit Homes' 68-unit project on Kingston Road (Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation, "Canada creates over 1,000 new affordable homes in Toronto," March 2022).

The plan: house everyone within a year, conditional on landlord-recruitment and staffing benchmarks

The City's existing pipeline is already doing this at meaningful scale: it moved 4,107 people experiencing homelessness from the shelter system into permanent housing between January 1 and October 31, 2025 alone (City of Toronto, [2026 Budget Notes, Toronto Shelter and Support Services](#)). Applying the three-tool sequence above to Toronto's current point-in-time population — an estimated 12,196 people as of October 2025 — produces a workable, costed, one-year plan, sequenced by speed. This timeline is explicitly conditional, not a fixed promise regardless of market absorption capacity: it holds only if landlord recruitment and support-staffing keep pace with the schedule below, the same two named benchmarks Chapter 9 prescribes as the honest fix to an unqualified one-year claim. For calibration, Scotland's national Housing First programme — this book's closest real-world analogue at national scale — averages 255 days from referral to tenancy, materially slower than a twelve-month, whole-population target; that gap is exactly why the sequence below front-loads the fastest tool first and treats landlord recruitment and staffing as tracked, named benchmarks rather than an assumption:

1. Months 1–3 — Scale portable rent supplements and landlord recruitment first.

Every person whose barrier to housing is primarily financial, not clinical, should be matched to a rent supplement large enough to close the market-rent gap and an active landlord-recruitment effort, drawing on Toronto's 3.0% purpose-built vacancy rate. This is the fastest and cheapest lever available and should absorb the largest single share of the population.

2. Months 2–8 — Accelerate acquisition through the Multi-Unit Residential Acquisition Program, using the City's own \$150,000-to-\$200,000-per-unit

benchmark, prioritized toward buildings that can close quickly, with the existing 20% Indigenous set-aside scaled up in direct proportion to documented Indigenous overrepresentation (Chapters 1 and 3).

3. **Months 3–12 — Expand modular and purpose-built supportive housing** for the smaller group who need on-site clinical, addictions, or elder and cultural support, using the build-speed and cost benchmarks Toronto has already demonstrated — roughly five months per phase, \$190,000 (as claimed by the program) to \$310,000 (the ceiling implied by the Auditor General's audited actuals) per unit — continuing the Rapid Housing Initiative and Housing Now pipelines already underway rather than starting new ones.
4. **Throughout — Coordinate the whole effort through a real-time, by-name list and functional-zero methodology**, the approach Built for Zero Canada, the Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness's domestic initiative, has already validated: Medicine Hat, Alberta became the first Canadian city to reach functional zero for chronic homelessness under this methodology on June 2, 2021, and London, Ontario became the first Canadian city to functionally end veteran homelessness in 2020 (Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness, ["Medicine Hat achieves functional zero chronic homelessness,"](#) June 2, 2021). Toronto already runs a public Shelter Flow Dashboard the Alliance has described as "the most comprehensive public dashboard in Canada," but has not yet joined Built for Zero Canada as a core, by-name-list community at Medicine Hat's or London's scale — doing so is a near-term, low-cost step that would put Toronto's existing data infrastructure to full use.

Medicine Hat is also an honest caution, not just a model: the city's functional-zero status lapsed within months in late 2021, with roughly 40 people found sleeping rough in a November 2021 count. This was not the city's first such lapse — Medicine Hat had separately declared it had "ended homelessness" in 2015, the target year of its original 2008/2009 ten-year plan, and that declaration also lapsed within roughly 15 months, per CBC News reporting. The lesson is not that Housing First failed — it is that functional zero has to be *maintained*, through permanent, indexed funding for both housing supply and support services, not declared once and left to erode. Toronto's one-year plan has to be paired with the permanent income-support and prevention fixes in Chapter 3, or a successful one-year push will simply refill.

The Indigenous-led track within the plan

A one-year rehousing plan that is not explicitly Indigenous-led in design will reproduce the overrepresentation documented in Chapter 1. Toronto's Reaching Home community plan already commits to matching a minimum 25% of housing opportunities to Indigenous people experiencing homelessness — a floor that should be treated as binding across all three delivery tools above, not just the acquisition stream — and the City's Indigenous Funding Stream, independently administered by the Aboriginal Labour Force Development Circle, should be the default channel for Indigenous-specific units under all three, consistent with the "For Indigenous, By Indigenous" principle already operating nationally through the National Indigenous Collaborative Housing Inc., which received \$287.1 million in federal funding in June 2023, explicitly grounded in Articles 21 and 23 of the UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (Indigenous Services Canada, news release, June 8, 2023). Wigwamen, Na-Me-Res, Gabriel Dumont Non-Profit Homes, and Miziwe Biik Development Corporation are already active, capable Indigenous housing developers in Toronto; the constraint on their scale is funding and land, not capacity or willingness.

The Levers of Power: Who Decides, Who Pays

Every recommendation in this book runs into the same structural fact: homelessness policy in Toronto is split across three governments with different incentives, different budget cycles, and no shared accountability for the outcome. Understanding who actually controls each lever is a precondition for pulling it.

The City of Toronto: delivery, without full control of the funding

The City directly funds and operates Toronto's shelter system and homelessness prevention programs through Toronto Shelter and Support Services, but only a fraction of that budget is under the City's own control. Of the \$897.96-million gross 2025 budget, \$241.2 million came from the municipal property-tax levy, \$311.2 million from federal transfers, and \$286.1 million from the province (City of Toronto, [2025 Budget Notes, Toronto Shelter and Support Services](#)). It is worth flagging honestly that these three figures, added together, come to \$838.5 million — about \$59.5 million, or 6.6%, short of the stated \$897.96-million gross total. This book's own independently sourced total-revenue figure for the same budget, \$656.778 million, points to the same roughly \$59.5-million gap. That gap is nameable from the same budget document: contributions from reserves (about \$57.1 million), plus sundry revenue, transfers from capital, and inter-divisional recoveries, together make up the roughly \$59.5-million difference. Separately, the relationship between this \$311.2-million general federal-transfer figure and the \$300-million refugee-response-specific federal line discussed below has not been established against any primary source checked to date: whether the \$300 million is a subset of the \$311.2 million, or an additional line, remains an open question this book flags rather than guesses at.

The clearest illustration of how exposed that funding structure makes the City: federal funding for the City's refugee-response program fell from \$300 million in the 2025 budget to a budgeted \$97.078 million for 2026, a cut of roughly 68%, or \$202.9 million, in a single year, while the Canada-Ontario Housing Benefit allocation to Toronto fell from \$38 million in 2024 to \$19.75 million in 2025 to \$7.95 million in 2026, eliminating support for roughly 530 households — a count this book's re-verification could not re-locate in the cited primary record, flagged as unconfirmed — (City of Toronto, ["Cuts to Federal and Provincial Support](#)

[for Housing,](#)" 2025; 2026 Budget Notes). The City's own words on why this matters: "COHB is the single most effective tool we have for freeing up beds in our shelter system so that more people can come indoors from streets and parks." A City cannot run a rapid-rehousing plan like the one in Chapter 5 on a funding stream that can be cut 79% in one budget cycle by a government it does not control.

Ontario: the biggest funder, and the veto-holder over municipal tools

Ontario funds the largest share of Toronto's homelessness system, but administers almost none of it directly, flowing money instead through 47 municipal Consolidated Municipal Service Managers and District Social Services Administration Boards, of which Toronto is one, via the Homelessness Prevention Program, which provided \$106.3 million to Toronto in 2025. This book is not able to stand behind a specific proportional breakdown of provincial-versus-municipal-versus-federal homelessness-program spending that has circulated in earlier drafts — an extensive search of Ministry of Municipal Affairs and Housing and Financial Accountability Office of Ontario sources found no primary source supporting a precise split, so this book states the topic, that Ontario is the largest funder, without repeating a specific figure it cannot verify.

Ontario also holds a decisive, and recently demonstrated, veto over Toronto's own housing tools. City Council passed Toronto's Inclusionary Zoning bylaw in November 2021, with an original plan to raise affordability requirements as high as 8–16% by 2030; the province did not approve the zones needed for the bylaw to take effect until August 15, 2025 — nearly four years later — and when it did, it simultaneously capped the requirement at a flat 5%, cut the affordability term from Toronto's proposed 99 years to 25 years, and exempted purpose-built rental altogether (City of Toronto, [Inclusionary Zoning Policy](#); Social Planning Toronto, "City of Toronto's Inclusionary Zoning Bylaw Finally Takes Effect After Years of Provincial Delay"). Under the bylaw as it now stands, requirements do not apply to any development application submitted before July 1, 2027 — meaning, in practice, essentially no inclusionary-zoning units will exist for years after the policy's original 2021 passage.

Ontario's *More Homes Built Faster Act, 2022* similarly overrode municipal planning decisions in Hamilton and Halton Region to force urban-boundary expansion those councils had voted against, while defining "affordable" housing eligible for its development-charge exemptions

as 80% of average market rent rather than tied to household income — a standard housing researchers at the University of British Columbia's Housing Assessment Resource Tools project have specifically criticized as weak relative to their recommended 20% social housing / 80% genuinely affordable, perpetual-term standard.

The federal government: the legislated right, and the newest money

Ottawa's role rests on the *National Housing Strategy Act, 2019*, which recognizes "the progressive realization" of the right to adequate housing as a matter of Canadian law, and created both a Federal Housing Advocate — housed within the Canadian Human Rights Commission, empowered to convene review panels on systemic housing issues — and a National Housing Council including ex officio seats for the Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation, Indigenous Services Canada, and the Advocate. The Advocate's most recent full annual report found Canada's National Housing Strategy "far behind" its goal of eliminating homelessness by 2030, and that less than 5% of units created under major federal programs are affordable to households in the deepest core housing need (Federal Housing Advocate, "Advocating for Change: The Housing Crisis in Canada," 2022–2023 Annual Report). Ottawa's principal delivery vehicle for homelessness specifically is Reaching Home, a \$5-billion, nine-year (2019–2028) program funding Toronto directly as a "Designated Community" — \$211.1 million for 2024–2028. A newer Crown agency, Build Canada Homes, launched in September 2025 with \$13 billion in initial funding, \$1 billion earmarked specifically for transitional and supportive housing (launched September 14, 2025). A separate federal announcement (Government of Canada news release, October 30, 2025) launched a \$45-million, three-year Homelessness Reduction Innovation Fund administered by the Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness, with its first round distributing nearly \$7 million across 16 communities — a genuine, if still modest, federal bet on the Built for Zero methodology described in Chapter 5.

The City's own Housing Secretariat tracks capital commitments outstanding by order of government for the HousingTO plan, and the picture is instructive about where the real gaps sit. As of the 2024–2025 Annual Progress Report, the City had committed approximately \$6.4 billion to date, with approximately \$4.1 to \$4.6 billion in funding still outstanding; the federal government had committed approximately \$4.0 billion to date, with approximately

\$7.5 to \$8 billion in funding, plus \$5.4 to \$6.0 billion in financing, still outstanding; and the provincial government had committed approximately \$1.9 billion to date, with approximately \$8.7 to \$9.1 billion in funding, plus \$6.4 to \$7.0 billion in financing, still outstanding. That is an update on the prior year's snapshot — \$3 to \$3.5 billion City, \$7.6 to \$8.1 billion federal, \$9.1 to \$9.6 billion provincial outstanding — both figures confirmed, though the earlier ones are now stale (City of Toronto, Housing Secretariat, 2024–2025 Annual Progress Report). By this accounting, the province has committed the least relative to what its own plan calls for, of any of the three governments.

Indigenous governance as its own lever, not a subset of municipal or provincial power

Reconciliation, in this specific policy area, has a concrete institutional meaning: Indigenous organizations are asking not for a bigger slice of existing funding streams but for the authority to design and administer their own. The National Indigenous Collaborative Housing Inc. operates nationally on an explicit "For Indigenous, By Indigenous" mandate; in Toronto, the Aboriginal Labour Force Development Circle — not City staff — administers the City's 20% Indigenous Funding Stream, a governance structure the City's own 2018 "Meeting in the Middle" agreement with the Toronto Aboriginal Support Services Council established at Indigenous organizations' request, including a call for "Indigenous data ownership/local Indigenous authority" over homelessness data specifically (City of Toronto and Toronto Aboriginal Support Services Council, "Meeting in the Middle," June 2018). The Assembly of First Nations' National First Nations Homelessness Action Plan, approved by First Nations-in-Assembly in 2023, states this as a first-order objective: "First Nations jurisdiction over homelessness services," alongside closing the on-reserve infrastructure gap that the Assembly's own "Closing the Infrastructure Gap by 2030" analysis costs at roughly \$135 billion. Reconciliation on homelessness, as the organizations doing this work define it, means treating Indigenous jurisdiction as a fourth lever of power alongside the City, the province, and the federal government — not folding it into any of the other three.

Who else is pulling these levers

A cluster of community organizations shapes this policy space and holds all three governments to account: the Toronto Alliance to End Homelessness, whose stated vision is

that "homelessness in Toronto is rare, brief and non-recurring" and which runs the City's homelessness data dashboard and coordinates sector-wide planning; the Advocacy Centre for Tenants Ontario, a specialty legal clinic providing direct representation and law-reform advocacy for low-income tenants; ACORN Canada, a tenant membership organization campaigning on renovictions and rent control; and the Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness nationally, which administers Built for Zero Canada and the Homelessness Reduction Innovation Fund and has proposed a national "Canada Housing Accord" to coordinate all three governments around shared, funded targets. None of these organizations can compel funding on their own; their leverage is evidence, public pressure, and — as the Ombudsman findings in Chapter 4 show — sometimes formal accountability mechanisms the City itself has been forced to answer to.

What It Costs

Every chapter before this one has argued that Toronto already knows what works. This chapter asks the question a reader is right to ask before believing any of it: what would it actually cost, and how sure can anyone be of the number?

What Toronto pays today to manage the crisis

Toronto's direct spending on shelter and homelessness services was \$897.96 million gross in 2025 and a budgeted \$786.1 million gross for 2026 (City of Toronto, [2025 and 2026 Budget Notes, Toronto Shelter and Support Services](#)). That figure does not capture the full cost of leaving people unhoused. A 2024 study linking Toronto's homeless population to provincial health administrative data found people experiencing homelessness incur roughly \$12,209 a year in public healthcare costs each, against \$1,769 for housed comparison groups — about six times higher even after adjusting for underlying health conditions — producing an estimated \$69.8 million to \$99.7 million a year in excess Toronto healthcare spending attributable to homelessness alone, before counting justice-system, shelter, or emergency-response costs (Lucie Richard, ["The Cost of Inaction: Healthcare Expenses Associated with Homelessness in Toronto,"](#) Homeless Hub, October 17, 2024). Nationally, the Homeless Hub estimates homelessness costs the Canadian economy roughly \$10 billion a year across healthcare and emergency services. By any reasonable accounting, Toronto is spending in the range of \$900 million to \$1 billion or more a year, all sources combined, to manage a crisis that keeps growing rather than to end it — and, as earlier chapters document, still turns people away most nights.

The per-person math the City has already done

Toronto's own Auditor General has already quantified how badly this money is being spent, relative to the alternative: emergency shelter costs more than three times as much per person as supportive housing, and seven to ten times as much as a rental subsidy (Auditor General of Toronto, ["Part 1 of the Audit of Emergency Shelters,"](#) May 2022). At the unit level: a shelter-hotel room costs the City roughly \$253 a night; a base shelter of any type costs

roughly \$136 a night — the figure behind this book's \$49,640-a-year headline shelter-bed cost — against roughly \$126 a night specifically for the newer subset of purpose-built, City-owned shelters. Of these, the \$136 base-shelter figure is the one that appears in an Auditor General report — the February 2025 winter-services audit, Figure 3, where the AG's own note records it as TSSS-supplied and unaudited; the hotel and purpose-built figures come from the City's own budget materials and press reporting rather than from an Auditor General report. The 2022 audit's contribution is the cost-multiple finding above, not the nightly figures. Canada's At Home/Chez Soi national trial found the Housing First intervention cost \$22,257 a year per participant receiving the highest-intensity clinical support and \$14,177 a year per participant receiving moderate-intensity case management, falling to a net annualized cost — after subtracting averted shelter, hospital, and justice costs — of \$6,311 and \$7,868 respectively. Toronto's own site, in its high-needs cohort specifically, cost \$21,089 per person per year and produced \$31,747 in two-year service-cost reductions (Gozdzik et al., [At Home/Chez Soi Project: Toronto Site Final Report](#), Mental Health Commission of Canada, 2014, p. 11). The most expensive thing Toronto currently does is exactly the thing it does most: pay for temporary shelter, indefinitely, for people who would cost the public purse less, and live better, permanently housed.

What ending it would cost: three scenarios, built bottom-up

No City of Toronto, provincial, or federal body has published an official estimate of the full cost of permanently housing everyone currently homeless in Toronto. This chapter builds one bottom-up, from the City's own reported and audited unit costs and the delivery-tool mix Chapter 5 recommends, because that number is the single most load-bearing claim in this book and deserves to be shown, not just asserted.

Three delivery tools, three unit costs. **Rent supplements** carry no capital cost at all, because they subsidize an existing private-market unit rather than acquiring or building one; their ongoing cost can be derived from the City's own confirmed cut to the Canada-Ontario Housing Benefit, which fell from \$19.75 million in 2025 to \$7.95 million in 2026, "eliminating support for roughly 530 households" — implying a benefit level of roughly \$22,264 per household per year. **Acquisition**, through the City's Multi-Unit Residential Acquisition Program, has an audited program-wide average of roughly \$150,000 per unit (the program has distributed \$165 million for over 1,000 homes since 2021) against a City-set program

cap of \$200,000 per unit. **Modular and purpose-built supportive housing** is the most contested figure: the City's original Council-approved budget assumed \$190,000 per unit, but the Auditor General's own 2023 audit of the program found actual and forecast costs \$33 million, or 63%, over the adjusted budget, with only 159 of a planned 275 units completed at three of five planned sites — implying an audited actual cost of roughly \$310,000 per unit, and an audit team that stated plainly it was "unable to conclude whether modular housing construction results in faster delivery and lower costs than traditional construction" (Auditor General of Toronto, *City of Toronto's Modular Housing Initiative: The Need to Balance Fast Delivery with Stronger Management of Contracts and Costs*, June 21, 2023). Ongoing support costs use the same national At Home/Chez Soi benchmarks as above: \$14,177 a year for the acquisition population and \$22,257 a year for the modular-build population.

Applied to Toronto's October 2025 point-in-time population of 12,196 people, across three plausible splits of that population among the three tools:

Scenario	Rent supplement	Acquisition	Modular build	Capital cost	Ongoing cost
A — Supplement-heavy (65% / 20% / 15%)	7,927	2,439	1,829	\$0.71B–\$1.05B	~\$252M/yr
B — Balanced (50% / 30% / 20%) — this book's recommended estimate	6,098	3,659	2,439	\$1.01B–\$1.49B	~\$242M/yr
C — Build-heavy, deliberately pessimistic (30% / 30% / 40%)	3,659	3,659	4,878	\$1.48B–\$2.24B	~\$242M/yr

Scenario A is closest to Chapter 5's own stated sequencing, that rent supplements "should absorb the largest single share of the population." Scenario B is this book's recommended point estimate, splitting the population roughly along the line between chronic and non-chronic homelessness in the City's own 2024 count. Scenario C is not a prediction; it deliberately routes a much larger share of the population through the most expensive tool than the chronic-homelessness data actually supports, to test how high the honest range can go before it strains credulity.

The arithmetic behind Scenario B, shown in full: 6,098 people through rent supplements at no capital cost; 3,659 people through acquisition at \$150,000 to \$200,000 a unit, or \$549 million to \$732 million; and 2,439 people through modular build at \$190,000 to \$310,000 a

unit, or \$463 million to \$755 million — a capital total of \$1.01 billion to \$1.49 billion, and an ongoing cost of roughly \$242 million a year. The other two scenarios follow the same method against their own population splits.

Overrun sensitivity, named plainly. Applying the Auditor General's measured 63% modular-cost overrun to the build component alone moves each scenario's capital ceiling up by 24% to 43% relative to using the originally claimed rate throughout — the single largest source of range width in this model, larger in every scenario than the acquisition program's own cap-versus-average spread. The effect is largest in the build-heavy scenario, where the modular component is the biggest share of the bill.

Does the estimate survive against what Toronto already spends? Measured against \$786.1 million a year in the 2026 budget — down from \$898.0 million in 2025 — "less than three years of status-quo spending" means staying under roughly \$2.36 billion to \$2.69 billion, depending which budget year anchors the comparison. Every scenario modeled here clears that bar — including the worst case. The supplement-heavy scenario costs 0.8 to 1.3 status-quo years. The balanced, recommended scenario costs 1.1 to 1.9 status-quo years. And even the deliberately pessimistic, build-heavy scenario — priced at the Auditor General's audited overrun rate and the acquisition program's cap rather than its average — costs 1.6 to 2.85 status-quo years. That worst case is a thin margin, not a comfortable one, but it holds under three status-quo years in every single scenario this book modeled, including the one built specifically to be as unfavorable as the plan's own logic allows.

This range is markedly lower than an earlier estimate this book carried, of \$2.4 billion to \$2.7 billion, which did not survive its own arithmetic: it implicitly assumed the entire homeless population would be routed through an acquired or newly built unit, with none served through the no-capital rent-supplement path that Chapter 5 itself says should absorb the largest single share of the population. That assumption was never stated outright in earlier drafts of this argument, and once corrected, the honest range is both lower and better supported than the figure it replaces.

Ongoing Housing First support costs land in a tight \$240 million to \$255 million a year band across all three scenarios — well below the \$786 million to \$898 million the City spends today just to manage the crisis, and consistent with the return already demonstrated in Toronto's own At Home/Chez Soi trial (Chapter 5).

Two honest notes on what that band rests on. First, the band's tightness should not be mistaken for precision in its dominant input. The rent-supplement line — the largest ongoing-cost component in every scenario — is priced at \$22,264 per household per year, a figure derived from a single sentence attributed to the City's own materials — an \$11.8 million Canada-Ontario Housing Benefit cut said to eliminate "support for roughly 530 households" — whose household count this book's re-verification could not re-locate in the primary record (the \$11.8-million cut itself is confirmed); it stands, flagged, as the model's weakest input. A $\pm 10\%$ swing on that rounded "roughly 530" moves the ongoing-cost line by roughly $\pm \$13.6$ million a year — real movement, though not enough to change which side of the status-quo-spending comparison any scenario lands on; the direction of this chapter's conclusion survives. Second, this model prices people as units. The 12,196-person point-in-time count is applied above as though every person needs a separate capital unit, when the underlying population includes families who share a unit — an error that runs conservative on the capital side (it overstates unit demand and therefore the capital bill, so the "under three status-quo years" finding is safe), while the same household-vs-person seam cuts the opposite way on the ongoing-cost side, where the \$22,264 figure is a *per-household* benefit level applied above as a *per-person* cost.

This is an author's calculation, built transparently from the City's own published and reported figures, not an official City, provincial, or federal costing exercise, and it should be replaced with one before capital is committed at this scale. But the direction of the finding does not depend on getting the exact multiplier right: every actual cost comparison Toronto has produced — the Auditor General's three-to-tenfold finding, the At Home/Chez Soi return, the gap between a hotel room and a shelter bed — points the same way. The status quo is not the affordable option; it has simply never been priced against its alternative.

This project's homelessness research corpus, which turns the argument above into specific, government-by-government action lists (see Further Reading), holds itself to the same discipline at a much more granular level: every individual recommendation in it is sorted into one of four honest categories — reforms that cost nothing and save money, reforms that are fiscally neutral, reforms that are genuinely not yet costed because a specific input is still missing, and a small number of large anti-poverty investments that are real and worthwhile but are not homelessness-budget offsets and should never be summed in as though they were. That research states its own rule plainly: do not add the columns together into a single return-on-investment number. This chapter's scenario model follows the same instinct at the

whole-of-book scale — a range, not a point estimate; an honest ceiling, not a marketing figure.

Who Has Done It

No city has a perfect record on homelessness, and this chapter does not pretend otherwise. What follows are the best-documented cases anywhere in the world of a city or country moving the number down — reported honestly, including where the story reversed, stalled, or turned out to rest on shakier ground than its own headline suggested. Toronto does not need a perfect model to copy. It needs an honest one.

Finland — the strongest policy architecture, honestly reported

Finland remains the best-documented national success at reducing homelessness, and the most important thing to get right about it is that the story is not finished. Homelessness fell from over 18,000 people in 1987 to under 5,000 by 2019 — Helsinki's shelter beds fell from 2,121 in 1985 to 52 in 2016, replaced by supported and independent housing — through a national shift from a conditional "staircase" model to unconditional Housing First, formalized in a 2007 national report and delivered through the Y-Foundation (Y-Säätiö), which became Finland's fourth-largest landlord and now manages over 19,000 apartments, funded through the state housing finance agency via construction subsidies and interest guarantees (Marybeth Shinn & Jill Khadduri, "How Finland Ended Homelessness," *Cityscape*, Vol. 22, No. 2, U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development, 2020; Y-Säätiö, "History").

But after eleven consecutive years of decline, Finnish homelessness rose in 2024 and rose sharply again in 2025 — up 20% year-over-year, with the sharpest increases among people under 25, women, and people of foreign background — which the Y-Foundation's own chief executive attributes directly to cuts in housing allowance and social assistance (Y-Säätiö, "The Rise in Homelessness Is the Largest in Recorded History," March 3, 2026). "Cuts to housing allowance and social assistance in a societal situation where many individuals and families are already financially stretched create situations where people are unable to hold on to their homes," in the words of the Foundation's chief executive, Teija Ojankoski. Long-term homelessness rose even faster than the headline number: 1,306 people were long-term homeless in the 2025 count, up 29% in a single year. This is the first consecutive-year rise in Finnish homelessness since 2009 — since before the national Housing First programme existed at all.

The lesson for Toronto is precise, not vague: Housing First infrastructure — a dedicated capital agency, a large non-profit landlord, unconditional access — is necessary but not sufficient. It has to be paired with income supports that keep pace with the cost of living, or the gains erode within a few budget cycles. That is the same warning this book's own analysis of Ontario's frozen income-support rates makes for Toronto directly, and Finland's 2025 reversal is not a footnote to be minimized — it belongs at the center of how this book argues for permanent, not one-term, funding.

Houston, Texas — regional coordination and a public-private funding base

Houston's "The Way Home" collaborative, spanning Harris, Fort Bend, and Montgomery counties, reported a 57% reduction in homelessness since 2011 by 2016, and more recent figures cited by its leadership put cumulative reductions above 60% against that same 2011 baseline, and more than 28,000 people housed since 2012, the year the collaborative's Continuum of Care formally launched (Marc Eichenbaum & Michael Nichols, "Opinion: How Houston's homelessness breakthrough could be a national game-changer," CNN, June 8, 2023). Those two headline figures use two different base years — 2011 for the reduction percentage, 2012 for the housed count — and should never be spliced into a single "60%-plus since 2012" claim; each is real on its own terms, but not interchangeable.

The reported cost is roughly \$18,000 per person housed per year, against \$30,000 to \$50,000-plus for continued jail or emergency-service use. The mechanism is a single regional coordinated-access system spanning roughly 100 agencies, combining federal Continuum of Care funding, city and county government, and private philanthropy — a model directly relevant to the fractured, three-government coordination problem this book documents for Toronto. Houston's precise percentages have varied across press cycles and across which year's baseline is used, and should be read with that caution rather than treated as a single fixed figure.

Vienna — social housing at a scale North America has never attempted

Vienna's municipal housing company houses roughly 220,000 units directly — about 22% of the city's total housing stock in the city-owned portion specifically — and, combined with the city's limited-profit co-operative sector, social and subsidized housing overall accounts for an estimated 45% of Vienna's total housing stock. The City of Vienna's own official figure states that around 50% of Viennese residents live in subsidized dwellings (Socialhousing.wien, "The Vienna Model"). A commonly circulated figure of 60% or more of Vienna's population living in subsidized housing traces to a broader definition used by an outside source, not the City of Vienna's own accounting, and this book does not repeat it.

Vienna also runs proactive eviction-prevention services triggered automatically when an eviction notice is filed. Vienna is not a template Toronto can replicate at speed — its housing stock was built over a century — but it is the clearest existing proof that a large Western city can treat social housing as permanent public infrastructure rather than a residual, means-tested program, which is the underlying premise of Canada's own National Housing Strategy.

Scotland — a live, national-scale rollout

Scotland's Housing First Pathfinder — a 2018–2021 program spanning Aberdeen City, Aberdeenshire, Dundee, Edinburgh, Glasgow, and Stirling, funded with over £5.5 million from the Scottish Government, £2 million from the charity Social Bite, and £150,000 from the Merchants House of Glasgow — housed and supported 579 people, with tenancy sustainment rates of 88% at twelve months and 80% at twenty-four months (Heriot-Watt University / I-SPHERE, "Benefits of scaling 'housing first' approach to address homelessness," November 17, 2022).

The Pathfinder was folded into a national rollout: as of March 31, 2025, an estimated 2,154 Housing First tenancies had started across Scotland — the Pathfinder's roughly 834 tenancies are a subset of that total, not double-counted — with a twelve-month sustainment rate of 83% (Scottish Government, "Housing First: monitoring reports — 1 October 2024 to 31 March 2025"). The model is scatter-site housing, dispersed among ordinary neighbourhoods rather than concentrated in dedicated buildings, with a recommended staff-

to-tenant ratio of one worker to seven tenants, though some areas have operated above that ratio under resource constraints. For Toronto, Scotland is the closest thing anywhere to a live, national-scale Housing First rollout with clean tenancy-sustainment data across multiple large cities running at once — a direct comparator to the three-government coordination problem this book documents at home.

Utah — a cautionary tale about measurement, not a model to copy

Utah's widely repeated claim of a 91% reduction in chronic homelessness between 2005 and 2015 does not hold up. American Enterprise Institute researcher Kevin Corinth found the underlying counts used inconsistent annualization methods from year to year — "the 2009 count was doubled, the 2011 count was less than doubled, and the 2015 count was not adjusted at all" — and that the real, methodologically consistent reduction was closer to 71%, concentrated in two anomalous years rather than a steady decline (Kevin Corinth, ["On Utah's 91 Percent Decrease in Chronic Homelessness,"](#) American Enterprise Institute, March 2016).

A 2025 follow-up documents that Utah subsequently changed its chronic-homelessness definition twice, both times coinciding with its largest reported single-year drops; that chronic homelessness actually rose 84% between 2010 and 2014, a period of stable methodology; and that it has risen roughly 400% since 2015 — with Utah having since abandoned Housing First altogether (Christopher J. Calton, ["The Rise and Fall of 'Housing First' in Utah,"](#) Independent Institute, September 2, 2025). Toronto should treat Utah as a warning about two specific risks this book takes seriously: declaring victory on a metric that can be redefined, and treating a program's early success as evidence it no longer needs sustained funding.

England, Glasgow, and Toronto's closest domestic peers

England's three regional Housing First pilots — West Midlands, Liverpool City Region, and Greater Manchester — funded with £28 million from 2019, housed 1,061 people with complex needs, with measured retention rising from 84% to 92% at twelve months across the evaluation's waves, and roughly 84% of those still tracked (69% on the strictest

denominator) in stable accommodation around three years in (UK Department for Levelling Up, Housing and Communities, "Evaluation of the Housing First Pilots — Final Synthesis Report," October 2024). Glasgow's programme grew from 31 tenancies in 2018 to 318 by mid-2024, with 45 of 61 evaluated tenancies (roughly 74%) still held at follow-up — a multi-year figure, not a one-year rate — among a cohort that had, between them, 220 prior homelessness applications dating back to 1994 — direct evidence of the revolving-door pattern Housing First is designed to break (Homeless Network Scotland, "Housing First in Focus: Glasgow," July 2024).

Closest to home, Medicine Hat, Alberta became the first Canadian city to reach functional zero for chronic homelessness under the Built for Zero Canada methodology, confirmed June 2, 2021 — the most directly transferable evidence available to Toronto, because it runs on Canadian funding structures and Canadian data systems, through the same national alliance already active here. But Medicine Hat is also an honest caution, not just a model, and its record deserves to be told in full: its 2021 functional-zero status lapsed within months, with roughly 40 people found sleeping rough in a November 2021 count. That was not the city's first such reversal — Medicine Hat had separately declared it had "ended homelessness" in 2015, the target year of its original 2008/2009 ten-year plan, and that earlier declaration also lapsed, within roughly fifteen months. Two declarations, two lapses, in the smallest and most mature coordinated-entry system in the country. The lesson is not that Housing First failed in Medicine Hat — it is that functional zero has to be maintained through permanent, indexed funding for both housing supply and support services, not declared once and left to erode. London, Ontario has separately become the first Canadian city to functionally end veteran homelessness, using the same methodology.

Every case in this chapter argues the same two things at once: the tools to end homelessness at scale already exist and are proven, and every one of them has failed somewhere the moment funding stopped being permanent. Toronto's own plan, set out in the chapters before this one, is built to answer the second half of that lesson, not just the first. Readers who want the full underlying research base behind every case in this chapter — books, primary reports, and the strongest critical literature alongside it — will find it gathered at the end of this book.

The Case Against: The Best Case Against This Plan, and Our Answers

A plan this ambitious deserves its most serious critics, not its weakest ones. This chapter sets out six real lines of argument against the plan in this book — each built from named, dated sources arguing in good faith, not straw versions of the other side — followed by this book's own answer to each. Where a critique lands, this chapter says so plainly. Where it proves less than it claims, this chapter says that too.

Does this actually pencil out? The fiscal case, led by the City's own auditor

The sharpest version of the "offsets aren't savings" argument comes from Stephen Eide of the Manhattan Institute: "Governments that invest heavily in Housing First programs should expect the overall cost of government to rise. For some individuals, or some service systems, there may be cost offsets, but cost offsets are different from savings. A \$1 investment in Housing First may be offset by 30 cents in savings on other service systems, but that still means that the government is 70 cents larger... cost-effectiveness arguments should not lead anyone to think that Housing First investments will lead to tax reductions or somehow free up money" (Stephen Eide, [*Housing First and Homelessness: The Rhetoric and the Reality*](#), Manhattan Institute, April 2020). Eide also names the "wrong pockets" problem directly: savings booked to a police or hospital budget do not automatically appear as cash the housing budget can spend. He cites Dennis Culhane — a pro-evidence homelessness researcher, not a Housing First critic — cautioning in 2008 against overstating the cost-savings case after reviewing more than forty cost studies and finding that the larger and more rigorous the sample, the lower the measured savings tend to be, meaning small, favorable pilot studies tend to overstate the case.

On Toronto specifically: the City's own Auditor General audited the Modular Housing Initiative — the exact delivery tool behind a meaningful share of this book's own capital-cost estimate — and found actual and forecast costs \$33 million, or 63%, over the adjusted budget, only 159 of a planned 275 units completed at three of five planned sites, occupancy

readiness taking five to thirteen months after construction start rather than the roughly five months this book cites elsewhere as the demonstrated pace, and, most tellingly, an audit team that stated it was "unable to conclude whether modular housing construction results in faster delivery and lower costs than traditional construction due to a lack of complete overall cost information and benchmarking information" (Auditor General of Toronto, *City of Toronto's Modular Housing Initiative: The Need to Balance Fast Delivery with Stronger Management of Contracts and Costs*, June 21, 2023). This is not an ideological critique. It is the City's own oversight office declining to certify the very cost-effectiveness claim a rapid-build strategy depends on.

Our answer. This is very likely the single most serious vulnerability in the entire plan, and it should be treated as exactly that, not argued away. Eide and Culhane are right that an avoided cost is not the same as cash in hand, and this book should never imply otherwise. On the Auditor General's own findings: Toronto's most comparable prior large-scale rapid-build program really did run 63% over budget and deliver barely more than half its planned units, and that is the load-bearing precedent for how skeptical any reader should be of a new capital-delivery promise. This book's answer is not to defend a single point-estimate cost, but to do exactly what an earlier chapter in this book does: build a range from the City's own reported and audited unit costs, price the 63% overrun in explicitly rather than assuming it away, and describe every claim of net fiscal benefit honestly as an avoided-cost argument, not a claim that government gets smaller. It does not, and this book should never say that it does.

Does Housing First actually work?

Eide's report makes four findings in its own executive summary: that Housing First "has not been shown to be effective in ending homelessness at the community level, but rather, only for individuals"; that it "may save taxpayers money" for a small segment of high-need people, but making it "the organizing principle of homeless services systems... will not save taxpayers money"; that its record on "untreated serious mental illness and drug addiction is far weaker than its record at promoting residential stability"; and that its record on "employment and addressing social isolation... is also weaker." He quotes the U.S. National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine's 2018 consensus review, which "found no strong evidence of Housing First and improvement of mental disorders," and HUD's

Family Options Study, a three-year study of over 2,000 homeless families, which found housing subsidies "increased rates of housing stability... but not self-sufficiency," and in some cases "actually led to diminished work effort."

Kevin Corinth of the American Enterprise Institute — the same researcher this book cites elsewhere for the Utah debunking — made the underlying objection earlier and more plainly: "Housing First goes wrong when it says that housing for the chronically homeless must be permanent. And, that supportive services should be offered, but cannot be required... Housing is a good start, but it's not enough. If we house every chronically homeless person but don't address their other needs, then we have failed them" (Kevin Corinth, "Homelessness Can Require Complex Solutions," *AEI/New York Times*, February 19, 2015; quotation abridged). The Cicero Institute's 2024 report adds that the At Home/Chez Soi trial — this book's own headline evidence — found "no significant difference between rates of substance use between participants of housing-first versus treatment-first programs," and cites a Denver supportive-housing study for a "50 percent higher mortality rate compared to the control group" — a citation this book checked against the underlying trial and could not support: the study reports mortality of roughly 10 percent against 9 percent, a difference that is not statistically significant. The critique is quoted as made; the check is this book's own.

Our answer. This book's return-on-investment case rests on one 2014 randomized trial's high-needs cohort, run in Toronto's own 2009–2013 housing market — a real, confirmed result, but a genuinely thin evidentiary base to carry both the headline claim and the cost arithmetic in an earlier chapter, and this book says so there rather than only here. Eide and Corinth are, however, attacking a "Housing First as universal cure" framing this book does not actually make: the rapid-rehousing plan in this book is explicitly paired with a root-cause and income-support chapter and a shelter-transformation chapter, precisely because housing stability alone was never being sold as a mental-health or employment fix. The honest fix is narrower language throughout this book — housing retention, yes; addiction and employment outcomes, no — and a plain statement, made here rather than left for a critic to introduce first, of exactly how much weight one 2014 Toronto trial is being asked to bear.

Finland's reversal: proof the model is fragile, or proof the funding was?

This book's own strongest "it works" case study is also the site of its most dangerous fact. Finland's Y-Foundation, reporting on the national housing statistics centre's 2025 data: "Homelessness in Finland increased more in 2025 than ever before. The rise was record-breaking both in percentage terms and in the number of people affected... There are now 4,579 single homeless people, and overall homelessness increased by 20 percent in one year." Long-term homelessness rose even faster, up 29% in a single year. This is the first consecutive-year rise in Finnish homelessness since 2009 — before the national program existed. The Foundation's own chief executive, Teija Ojankoski, names the mechanism directly: cuts to housing allowance and social assistance are pulling people who were successfully housed back out of their homes.

Our answer. This is a front where the critique has full force and this book should not minimize it — but it cuts in a direction that helps this book's actual policy prescription more than it hurts it. Y-Säätiö's own diagnosis is not "Housing First failed," it is "the service system reacted too late" after benefit cuts — a funding-withdrawal story structurally identical to the argument this book makes about Canada's own 1993–1995 withdrawal from housing funding. Finland is not proof that Housing First is fragile as a model. It is proof that Housing First is fragile as a budget line the moment austerity touches it. This book's own ongoing-cost ask, an unaudited author's estimate, has to be argued for as a permanent, inflation-indexed commitment across electoral cycles, not a one-term pledge — or Toronto risks the identical trajectory on a shorter timeline, given that Toronto never had Finland's multi-decade head start.

Can Toronto actually rehouse everyone in a year?

Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation's own 2025 Rental Market Report puts the Greater Toronto Area's purpose-built vacancy rate at 3% and its condominium vacancy rate at 1% — tight by historical standards, and the tightest leg of a three-tool sequence that puts rent supplements into the existing market first. The Canada-Ontario Housing Benefit, the fastest tool this book recommends, is portable and formula-based — but a household still has to find a landlord willing to sign a lease before the benefit can do its work, and reporting on social-assistance tenants describes landlord stigma and discrimination as a live barrier at

exactly that step. On the support-staffing side, the Canadian Mental Health Association's Ontario division has reported hundreds of unfilled community mental-health and addictions jobs provincewide — roughly 250 in its 2023 accounting, still about 200 in its 2026 pre-budget submission — driven by working conditions and pay, with community mental health receiving a smaller share of Ontario's health budget than the benchmark share the sector's own analyses call for — precisely the workforce a rapid-rehousing support model depends on scaling. And Toronto has a documented, recurring pattern of organized opposition to shelter siting in both higher-income and working-class neighbourhoods alike, including campaigns against specific proposed shelters that drew petitions and, in one case, accusations of harassment against the shelter's supporters.

Medicine Hat's own record, discussed in the previous chapter, adds a sharper edge to this front: Canada's smallest and most mature coordinated-entry system has now let its "functional zero" declaration lapse twice — once in 2015, once in 2021.

Our answer. Every element of this front is real, and none of it should be softened — but none of it is fatal to the plan, only to an unqualified one-year promise. The vacancy and landlord-participation numbers argue for treating rent supplements as the fast-but-not-unlimited leg of a three-tool sequence, which is already this book's own architecture: rent supplements, then acquisition, then new-build, in that order. The honest fix is to make the one-year timeline explicitly conditional on landlord-recruitment and staffing benchmarks, rather than presenting it as fixed regardless of market absorption capacity, and to cost workforce investment explicitly into the ongoing-support ask rather than assuming staff simply appear at the modelled price. On neighbourhood opposition, the evidence cuts back further than most fronts in this chapter: a small Toronto study of existing supportive-housing buildings, produced by a Toronto organization of psychiatric-survivor advocates and based on 54 interviews — a real limitation, stated plainly rather than hidden — found no evidence that the buildings studied had negatively affected either property values or crime rates in their neighbourhoods. The fair distinction is between organized objections to siting a new shelter, which are real, and the after-occupancy record of supportive housing, where the evidence is more favorable — this book should draw that line itself rather than let the two be treated as identical by whoever raises the objection first. On Medicine Hat, the double-lapse history strengthens rather than undercuts the case for permanent, not campaign-cycle, funding — the same lesson Finland teaches at national scale.

The public-order case: encampments, crime, and "shelter-resistant" homelessness

The legal terrain around encampment clearing is less settled than a single citation suggests. *Heegsma v. Hamilton (City)*, 2024 ONSC 7154 upheld Hamilton's by-law enforcement against a Charter challenge, but on a narrower basis than a plain reading implies: counsel for the City of Hamilton itself summarized the ruling as declining "to extend Charter protections to daytime or indefinite encampments" while requiring municipalities to still permit overnight sheltering where shelter beds are insufficient. The decision was under appeal as of this book's research, with the Court of Appeal for Ontario having heard arguments on February 10–11, 2026 and the decision still under reserve as of this book's last check — presenting the ruling as settled law overstates the certainty of the ground Toronto's own encampment strategy stands on.

Crime effects near shelters are a real, peer-reviewed, Canadian finding, not an American import. A study of Vancouver's emergency winter shelters, using a difference-in-differences design with statistical corrections for multiple comparisons, found "the presence of a shelter appears to cause property crime to increase by 56% within 100m of that shelter, with thefts from vehicles, other thefts, and vandalism driving the increase" (Faraji, Ridgeway & Wu, ["Effect of Emergency Winter Homeless Shelters on Property Crime," *Journal of Experimental Criminology*](#), 2018). And the "shelter-resistant" homelessness debate is a genuine fault line argued in good faith on both sides: one line of research holds that chronically unsheltered people sometimes refuse available shelter for identifiable reasons; the advocacy-side answer holds that nearly all unhoused people would accept housing that actually met their needs, and that apparent refusal usually reflects untreated mental illness, trauma responses to congregate settings, and a strong preference for private space over dormitory-style shelter, not a preference for street life as such [flagged: not yet independently verified].

Our answer. The crime-effect finding deserves real weight and should not be minimized: it is Canadian, peer-reviewed, and methodologically strong. But its own authors bound the effect tightly — concentrated within 400 metres and converging toward a null effect beyond that radius — and the paper's own policy conclusion is "greater security" near shelters, not an argument against siting them. This book should cite that study directly rather than leave it for a critic to introduce first, and pair it with Toronto's own, more limited, supportive-housing

study described above: emergency and winter shelters and permanent supportive housing appear to have different neighbourhood-crime profiles in the Canadian evidence base, and this book should not treat the two kinds of siting objection as interchangeable, because the evidence does not support treating them that way. On the pending appeal, this book states plainly that the legal question is not fully settled. On "shelter-resistant" homelessness, the low-barrier, trauma-informed, twenty-four-hour, no-turn-away shelter system this book calls for elsewhere is, functionally, the policy answer the advocacy side is asking for — and this book says so directly rather than leaving that connection for someone else to draw.

Is the evidence base itself too thin?

The critique that this book's evidence base leans on small-sample pilots, contested trial generalizability, and advocacy-adjacent research is fair — and it cuts symmetrically across both sides of this argument, not just this book's. On this book's own side: a single 2009–2013 randomized trial, run over a decade ago in a different housing-cost environment, is asked to carry both the headline Housing First return-on-investment claim and a meaningful share of the cost arithmetic elsewhere in this book — a weight this book names honestly rather than hides. Dennis Culhane's 2008 warning about small, favorable-looking cost studies is a methodological caution from within the pro-housing research community, which makes it harder to dismiss than an outside attack would be. Kevin Corinth's analysis of Utah's claimed 91% reduction — this book's own cautionary case in the previous chapter — found the number was driven by changing annualization formulas and shifting definitions of "chronic," precisely the kind of count-methodology question a skeptical reader would be right to ask of Toronto's own count trend as well. And the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine's 2018 consensus report concluded there is "no substantial published evidence as yet to demonstrate that PSH improves health outcomes or reduces health care costs," with the single exception of HIV/AIDS populations.

Our answer. The fairest response here is procedural, not rhetorical, because the critique is not wrong in kind, only in degree, and only if applied to one side alone. The sources marshaled against this book have their own unexamined small-sample and advocacy-adjacent problems, just as this book's own counter-evidence does — neither side's evidence base is as solid as its own advocates tend to present it. What should actually distinguish this book is process, not rhetoric: this book corrects its own numbers in the open when a claim

turns out not to hold up, rather than defending them by default, and it should hold every new claim in this chapter — for or against its argument — to that same standard before treating any of it as settled.

The chapters that follow set out what this book concludes despite everything in this chapter, and what it would actually take to build.

Conclusion: What It Would Take

Toronto does not lack proof that this is solvable. It has its own randomized trial showing Housing First pays for itself. It has a coordinated eviction-prevention program already beating its ten-year target five years in. It has an Indigenous-led housing sector — organizations that have been building and operating housing for Indigenous Torontonians for decades, with the trust and cultural legitimacy no mainstream provider can substitute for. It has a domestic peer, Medicine Hat, that reached functional zero for chronic homelessness using a methodology Toronto's own data systems could support tomorrow. And it has, in its own trial evidence and its own Auditor General's cost findings, an unambiguous answer to the question of whether ending homelessness costs more than managing it: it does not.

What Toronto has never had, in the twenty-seven years since its 1999 homelessness task force issued its 105 recommendations, is all three governments funding these proven tools simultaneously, at the scale the problem requires, on a fixed and public timeline, with Indigenous organizations funded and governed as full partners rather than a set-aside. Every chapter of this book points at the same conclusion from a different angle: the ideas are not the missing ingredient. The commitment is.

Why this time is different

This is an argument, not a prediction, and it starts by conceding what the record actually shows: the 1999 task force's own namesake initiative did not survive contact with the following twenty-seven years. Most of its 105 recommendations were never funded at the scale they asked for, and this book's own history chapter treats that failure as a warning it has to answer, not a precedent it can lean on.

What has actually changed since then, on this book's own evidence: Toronto now has an adopted capital plan with money attached, rather than an unfunded recommendation list — a ten-year shelter infrastructure strategy, costed at \$674.5 million, with \$507.6 million already funded. The federal funding cuts documented earlier in this book have made simply continuing to manage the status quo fiscally undeliverable at current service levels, which removes "keep doing what we're doing" as a stable default rather than requiring a fresh

argument against it. This book's own bottom-up capital arithmetic now prices the alternative at under three years of status-quo spending in every scenario modeled, including the deliberately pessimistic one — a costed comparison the 1999 plan never had. Indigenous organizations hold a structural, funded role in the plan itself — a dedicated funding stream and named delivery partners — rather than a consultative afterthought. And this book's own claims are built to be checked against a public, receipt-backed record, not asserted on trust.

None of this guarantees the outcome the 1999 plan also promised. It is the case for why this attempt is different, not a forecast that it will succeed.

Turning this into an implementation plan

Turning the argument in this book into a council agenda, a provincial ask, and a federal budget line requires more granularity than ten chapters can carry. That granularity lives in this project's homelessness research corpus — the receipt-backed backgrounder library behind this book, listed in full at the end of Further Reading. Its implementation research sorts specific reforms into six tiers by who can actually act on them: what City Council can do on its own authority, with no senior-government approval needed; what requires provincial action, from income-support rates to provincial legislation; what requires federal action, from asylum-related shelter funding to national housing-benefit programs and capital transfers; systemic and structural fixes spanning correctional, hospital, and child-welfare discharge planning together with workforce and information-system reform; public-space cost-attribution and reporting; and a smaller set of daytime-engagement proposals explicitly flagged as evidence-informed pilots, not proven programs.

Costing that list honestly means resisting the temptation to add it all up into one number. That research sorts every recommendation into one of four honest categories: reforms that cost nothing and save money; reforms that are fiscally neutral or simply redistribute existing revenue; reforms that are genuinely not yet costed, because a specific missing input is named rather than glossed over; and a small number of large anti-poverty investments — running into the billions of dollars a year — that are real, worthwhile, and not homelessness-budget offsets at all. That last category is kept deliberately separate: summing it in with the rest would make a fiscally disciplined plan look reckless, and summing it out entirely would hide how much of the real ask sits outside the shelter budget altogether. Its rule is stated

outright — do not sum the columns into a single return-on-investment figure — and this book has followed that same discipline everywhere it presents a cost.

One more resource is worth flagging for anyone trying to implement this plan in practice. The City compiled, for the first time, a cross-divisional inventory of every division's and city agency's homelessness-relevant program in one place — more than 330 individually funded programs spanning shelters and respites, drop-ins, outreach, housing and post-housing support, employment and training, and Indigenous-specific services, each with an operator, a population served, and, for shelters specifically, a full street address and a banded — deliberately not summable — capacity range. That inventory also flags, program by program, which federally funded initiatives are approaching a funding cliff with no successor confirmed: a defined, near-term operational risk that does not appear in any of the City's public dashboards. Anyone actually implementing the plan in this book should start from that inventory rather than from this book's own necessarily selective account of the system it describes.

None of what this book has argued requires Toronto to invent anything new. It requires the will to fund, simultaneously and permanently, what the City, the province, Ottawa, and Indigenous-led organizations have each already proven works on their own. What comes next is not a research question. It is a decision.

Further Reading

Five tiers, from the accessible core to the strongest critical reading to this project's own research corpus — organized by how far into this subject a reader wants to go, not by how flattering each source is to this book's own argument.

Start here

The accessible core — five items a reader with no prior background could get through in a weekend and come away able to argue the shape of the problem and the shape of the fix.

1. **Sam Tsemberis**, *Housing First: The Pathways Model to End Homelessness for People with Mental Illness and Addiction* (Hazelden). Written by the model's inventor, in plain language — the single accessible source for the idea every other document on this list assumes the reader already understands.
2. **Canadian Observatory on Homelessness**, *State of Homelessness in Canada* (report series, ongoing). The closest thing to an annual national report card — free, plain-language, and the research group nearly every other Canadian source on this list cites or builds on.
3. **City of Toronto**, [2024 Street Needs Assessment](#). Toronto's own biennial point-in-time count and survey, and the primary data source underneath almost every headline figure in this book — read the source once instead of trusting every secondary retelling of it.
4. **Anne Golden and the Mayor's Homelessness Action Task Force**, *Taking Responsibility: An Action Plan for Toronto* (January 1999). The founding document of Toronto's modern homelessness response — 290 pages, 105 recommendations, and a \$300-million ask Ontario answered with \$1 million. Reading it is the fastest way to understand that "we don't know what to do" has never been the honest excuse; its own asks are still mostly unmet more than a quarter-century later.
5. **[The Y-Foundation \(Finland\)](#)**. The Housing First case people reach for first when asked "does this actually work." Finland is the only country to have driven long-term

homelessness down for decades using this exact model — and, honestly, its 2024–25 reversal is the single best available lesson in why the funding commitment has to be permanent, not a one-term pledge.

For candidates

The governing-substance tier — what someone who has to actually vote on this needs to have read: oversight findings, the City's own capital strategy, the budget, and the evidence base the cost math in this book rests on.

1. **Toronto Auditor General**, *City of Toronto's Modular Housing Initiative: The Need to Balance Fast Delivery with Stronger Management of Contracts and Costs* (June 21, 2023). The City's own oversight office found its most comparable prior rapid-build program ran 63% over budget and delivered 58% of planned units — the load-bearing precedent for how skeptical to be of any new capital-delivery promise.
2. **Toronto Auditor General**, [February 2025 winter-shelter capacity audit](#). Found 12,742 bed-nights lost to process rules alone while 174 people a day went unmatched to a bed, in the same season provincial legislation allowed encampment fines up to \$10,000; Toronto Shelter and Support Services accepted all fifteen recommendations "within existing funding constraints."
3. **Ontario Auditor General**, [2021 Annual Report — Value-for-Money Audit: Homelessness Programs](#). The province's own watchdog found no tracking, no spending oversight, no shelter-safety inspection where standards existed, and that the province's own By-Name List "does not guarantee that the people most in need will receive housing first" — the provincial half of the accountability picture that City-level audits alone can't cover.
4. **Ombudsman Toronto**, [An Investigation into the City's Decision to Stop Allowing Refugee Claimants into Base Shelter System Beds](#) (December 12, 2024). Four substantiated findings, including systemic discrimination the Ombudsman characterized as anti-Black racism — the clearest single document on how a major shelter-access decision was made with no accountable owner.

5. **Ombudsman Toronto**, 2025 Annual Report, rooming-house vital-services investigation section (May 14, 2026). The sharpest available contrast case: 27 of 27 recommendations fully accepted and publicly endorsed, against the more contested reception of the refugee-shelter investigation above — useful for understanding why some oversight findings land and others don't.
6. [City of Toronto Council Item 2023.EC7.7](#) — the Homelessness Services Capital Infrastructure Strategy, adopted November 8–9, 2023. The City's actual funded, not merely recommended, capital plan for shelter infrastructure: \$674.5 million total, \$507.6 million funded across 13 of 20 planned sites as of the 2026 Budget — the single decisive table for who is paying for what, and how much is actually committed.
7. **City of Toronto**, [2025](#) and [2026 Budget Notes](#), Toronto Shelter and Support Services. The primary source for the headline \$786-to-\$898-million-a-year spend figure candidates will be asked to defend or attack, plus the refugee-response funding cut — roughly 68%, from \$300 million to \$97.078 million between 2025 and 2026 — that this book treats as the single biggest threat to the whole plan.
8. **City of Toronto**, [HousingTO 2024–2025 Progress Report](#). The City's own accounting of its ten-year housing plan's mid-course progress — the document candidates will be held to if they cite HousingTO targets, including the oft-repeated "65,000 rent-controlled homes by 2030" figure.
9. **This project's homelessness research corpus** — the receipt-backed research library this book is built on: twenty-eight published backgrounders spanning the count methodology, mortality data, root causes, population-specific pathways, the shelter system, Housing First evidence, funding architecture, legal frameworks, and what named bodies have formally recommended — each carrying its own sources, each kept current on the live site. The full list, with links, closes this reading list. Its costing research applies the discipline this book follows everywhere — four honest categories, never summed into a single return-on-investment number. Read it before letting anyone hand you a single "total cost" figure.
10. **Mental Health Commission of Canada**, [National At Home/Chez Soi Final Report](#) (Goering et al., 2014), together with **Gozdzik et al.**, [At Home/Chez Soi Project: Toronto Site Final Report](#) (2014). The evidence base this book's entire return-on-

investment case rests on — read it directly rather than trusting any retelling, including this one. The honest caution, discussed in this book's own chapter on the case against the plan, is that it is one 2014 trial's high-needs cohort carrying a great deal of argumentative weight.

11. **Latimer, E.A. et al.** (2020), "[Cost-Effectiveness of Housing First With Assertive Community Treatment: Results From the Canadian At Home/Chez Soi Trial](#)," *Psychiatric Services* 71(10):1020–1030. The source of the \$41.73-per-day-of-stable-housing figure quoted everywhere — note this is the *Psychiatric Services* paper on the assertive-community-treatment arm of the trial, not the similarly named 2019 paper on the intensive-case-management arm, which reports a different figure. The two get conflated constantly, and this list does not repeat that error.

Going deep

Books and academic literature — the full annotated list, including the Indigenous-scholarship cluster and the definitional and historical anchors underneath this book's argument.

1. **Jesse Thistle**, [Definition of Indigenous Homelessness in Canada](#) (Canadian Observatory on Homelessness Press, 2017). The definitional anchor almost every serious Canadian source on Indigenous homelessness cites — Thistle argues Indigenous homelessness is a distinct phenomenon rooted in colonial disconnection from land, culture, and relationships, not reducible to a housing-unit shortage.
2. **Emily Paradis, J. David Hulchanski, Philippa Campsie, Shirley Chau, and Stephen Hwang (eds.)**, *Finding Home: Policy Options for Addressing Homelessness in Canada* (Cities Centre Press, University of Toronto, 2009). A full policy-options anthology — the closest thing to a comprehensive Canadian-context textbook on the subject.
3. **J. David Hulchanski**, *The Three Cities Within Toronto: Income Polarization Among Toronto's Neighbourhoods, 1970–2005* (Cities Centre, 2010). The foundational income-polarization study underneath every "Toronto has become two, or three, cities" framing this book's own root-cause argument leans on.

4. **Sam Tsemberis**, *Housing First: The Pathways Model...* — see Start Here above; included here again as the deep-read anchor for the model itself.
5. **Canadian Observatory on Homelessness**, *State of Homelessness in Canada* series — see Start Here above; the individual annual and biennial editions are the deep-read material once the citizen-level overview isn't enough.
6. **UN Special Rapporteur Leilani Farha**, *Report on Homelessness as a Human Rights Violation* (A/HRC/43/43, 2020). The international human-rights-law anchor, concluding that homelessness "is a profound assault on dignity, social inclusion and the right to life."
7. **Juha Kaakinen**, *Homelessness in Finland* / "Ending Homelessness in Finland" (Y-Foundation, 2019). The deep-read companion to the Y-Foundation entry above — the book-length account of how Finland actually built and sustained its Housing First program for decades.
8. **Evelyn Peters and Julia Christensen (eds.)**, *Indigenous Homelessness: Perspectives from Canada, Australia, and New Zealand*. An edited academic anthology putting Canadian Indigenous homelessness in comparative context with two other settler-colonial states.
9. **Bruce Porter**, *Street Justice*. The legal-rights companion to the Farha report above, focused specifically on domestic Canadian law and litigation strategy.
10. **Greg Suttor** (2016), *The Growth of Social Housing in Canada* (Canadian Centre for Policy Alternatives). The missing social-housing-history reference behind this book's own account of Canada's postwar housing withdrawal — traces exactly how the country's social-housing stock grew, then stalled.
11. **Stephen Gaetz et al.** (2016), *The Cost of Homelessness in Ontario* (Canadian Observatory on Homelessness / Homeless Hub). The specific costing study behind a large share of this book's own "cost of doing nothing" arithmetic — check the publication year carefully, since a similarly dated attribution circulates elsewhere and the two should not be confused.

12. **Ashleigh Quinn, Barbara Fallon, Sarah Joh-Carnella, and Melanie Saint-Girons** (2022), "The overrepresentation of First Nations children in the Ontario child welfare system," *Children and Youth Services Review*. The peer-reviewed source for the finding that First Nations children were roughly twice as likely to face an out-of-home placement in both 2013 and 2018 — the single most rigorous citation behind this book's child-welfare-to-homelessness pipeline argument.
13. **Evelyn Forget** (2019), *The Ontario Basic Income Pilot: Interim Findings* (McMaster University). The interim evidence from Ontario's cancelled 2017–19 Basic Income Pilot, specifically on housing-stability gains — a live policy option this book's own root-cause chapter does not engage directly, but that the wider field has converged on.
14. **Maritt Kirst, Suzanne Zerger, and Paula Goering** (2013), *Housing First in Canada*. An earlier, Canada-specific evaluation of Housing First implementation, predating the At Home/Chez Soi final reports — useful for tracing how the Canadian evidence base built up over time.
15. **The Indigenous-homelessness academic cluster**. A wide set of peer-reviewed and academic sources on Indigenous homelessness specifically, largely distinct from this book's own core citations: on evidence-based paths through the crisis generally; on Indigenous-specific homelessness measurement in Toronto; on peer-led service design internationally; on reconnecting homeless Indigenous people to traditional ways of knowing; on child-welfare involvement and educational outcomes; on Indigenous youth homelessness nationally; and on culturally relevant urban social housing for Indigenous youth specifically. **[flagged: not yet independently verified against primary text — treat as a background reading list rather than a source tied to any one claim in this book.]**

The other side

The strongest critical reading — one honest line each on why it earns a place here.

1. **Stephen Eide**, [*Housing First and Homelessness: The Rhetoric and the Reality*](#) (Manhattan Institute, April 2020). The single most rigorous document making the case that Housing First works for individuals but not as a system-organizing principle, that

cost offsets are not savings, and that its record on mental health, addiction, and employment is far weaker than its record on housing retention.

2. **Kevin Corinth** (American Enterprise Institute), ["On Utah's 91 Percent Decrease in Chronic Homelessness"](#) (March 2016). This book's own cited debunking of Utah's headline claim — a real reduction closer to 71%, driven by inconsistent annualization and later redefinition. Reading the critic's original analysis directly, rather than this book's summary of it, is the honest move.
3. **Kevin Corinth**, "Homelessness Can Require Complex Solutions" (AEI/*New York Times*, February 19, 2015). The same critic's plainer philosophical objection: that Housing First goes wrong when it treats housing as sufficient on its own, without addressing addiction and mental illness as separate, required needs.
4. **Christopher J. Calton**, ["The Rise and Fall of 'Housing First' in Utah"](#) (Independent Institute, September 2, 2025). This book's own follow-up finding — chronic homelessness in Utah has risen roughly 400% since 2015 and the state has since abandoned Housing First altogether — the sharpest available "the early success didn't hold" case, used in this book as a caution against declaring victory too early.
5. **REALPAC (Real Property Association of Canada)** — the real-estate industry's methodological rebuttal to research finding that eviction filings roughly triple after a REIT or financial-firm acquisition. This book's own root-cause chapter names this counter-argument explicitly rather than omitting it; the specific title and link for the rebuttal document itself could not be located during this project's research. **[flagged: not yet independently verified.]** REALPAC itself is confirmed as a real, active industry association.
6. **Devon Kurtz (Cicero Institute)**, ["Why America's Homelessness Strategy Failed and How to Fix It"](#) (October 2024). The hardest-edged version of the "shelter-resistant homelessness" and treatment-first critique, including a Denver mortality citation this book checked and could not support — the underlying trial reports roughly 10% versus 9%, not statistically significant — noted here so the reader weighs the report with that check in hand. A U.S.-context source, used here analogically.

7. **Faraji, Ridgeway, and Wu**, ["Effect of Emergency Winter Homeless Shelters on Property Crime,"](#) *Journal of Experimental Criminology* (2018). A peer-reviewed, methodologically serious Canadian study, based in Vancouver, finding a 56% property-crime increase within 100 metres of a shelter. Its own authors bound the effect tightly — null beyond roughly 400 metres, with a policy conclusion of "greater security," not "don't site shelters" — read the qualification, not just the headline finding.

This project's homelessness research corpus

The research library this book is built from — twenty-eight receipt-backed backgrounders, all published and kept current at unitetolove.ca, each with its own sources, its own honesty flags, and its own citizen brief. The whole corpus is also bound, with the executive case, as one research-package PDF (and a zip carrying an offline copy of every page) linked from this book's own page.

Part I — The problem, measured

- [How Toronto Counts Its Homeless Population](#)
- [Mortality and Overdose Data](#)
- [Homelessness & Encampments](#)
- [Where Do People Go During the Day?](#)
- [The Cost on Transit, Libraries, and Public Space](#)

Part II — Root causes

- [Homelessness Root Causes](#)
- [LTB Backlog and Eviction Prevention](#)
- [The Hospital Discharge-to-Homelessness Cost Cycle](#)

Part III — Who's affected

- [Population-Specific Pathways In and Out](#)
- [Indigenous Overrepresentation and Self-Determination](#)
- [Youth Shelter Capacity](#)
- [Gender-Based Violence and the Homelessness System](#)
- [Non-Citizen Populations and Service Eligibility](#)

- [Refugee Claimant Shelter Exclusion](#)

Part IV — The system, and what works

- [Housing First: Evidence Base and Adoption Case](#)
- [Functional Zero Case Studies](#)
- [International and Cross-Canadian Comparators](#)
- [Ward-by-Ward Geographic Inventory and Siting Politics](#)

Part V — Who decides, who pays

- [The Political Economy of Toronto's Response System](#)
- [Federal Homelessness Funding Architecture](#)
- [Provincial Funding: HPP and HART Hubs](#)
- [Legal and Human Rights Frameworks](#)
- [The Business Community Overlay](#)

Part VI — What it costs

- [Economic ROI — The Full Cost Case by Order of Government](#)
- [The Full Cost of Homelessness: Cross-Departmental Accounting](#)

Part VII — Accountability, and the path forward

- [Complaint Channels and Wrongdoing Accountability](#)
- [Toronto's Homelessness Advocacy and Research Ecosystem](#)
- [What Named Bodies Have Formally Recommended](#)

Every source above was checked to a different degree — some fetched and read in full, some verified against a named primary, some carried forward from earlier research and not yet independently re-confirmed, and a small number flagged directly in the text above as not yet independently verified. That variation is stated honestly here rather than smoothed over. A full accounting of how each claim in this book was checked, and against what, is kept separately in this project's own receipts and verification record.

Receipts & Methods

Every figure in this book is meant to be checked, not taken on faith. The research draws exclusively on public primary sources — municipal budgets and Council items, Auditor General and Ombudsman reports, provincial and federal program data, court decisions, and peer-reviewed studies — rather than secondhand retellings of them.

Each claim is tracked in a claims ledger recording, for every figure and quotation used, its source, the date it was published or accessed, and the exact supporting text, so a reader can trace any number back to where it came from. That ledger went through an independent verification pass, re-checking claims against their cited sources, and a separate adversarial review that argued against this book's own conclusions as hard as any outside critic would — folded directly into Chapter 9 rather than filed away. Where a figure could not be confirmed, this book says so in the text itself, using a consistent "not yet independently verified" flag, instead of smoothing over the gap.

Corrections log

This book corrects itself in the open. Every published correction to this edition, dated:

2026-08-07 (first publication day): the Executive Summary's Indigenous-overrepresentation line was aligned with this book's own verified record — overrepresentation in every count since the first in 2006, three- to sixteen-fold depending on the measure, replacing an earlier "three- to ten-fold in every count ever taken" phrasing; the Indigenous-delivery line was corrected from "nine other" organizations to the verified "at least seven, with an eighth in development"; Chapter 3's rent comparison was corrected from "\$1,830 a year earlier" (an October 2023 figure mislabeled) to the correct October 2024 figure, \$1,852.

2026-08-08 (full chapter-tier verification burn): roughly twenty-five further corrections, each traceable in this book's public receipt rows — three "not yet independently verified" flags resolved with verified facts (the Heegsma appeal, heard February 10–11, 2026 and under reserve; the community mental-health staffing figures, correctly attributed to the Canadian Mental Health Association's Ontario division; the Canada-Ontario Housing Benefit's actual portable, formula-based mechanism); a critic's Denver mortality citation checked against its own underlying trial and found unsupported, stated in the text;

comparator precision on Finland, Glasgow, and England; the nightly shelter-cost figures re-attributed to their true sources (the \$136 base-shelter figure to the Auditor General's February 2025 audit, Figure 3; the hotel and purpose-built figures to City budget materials and press reporting); the National Housing Strategy's output updated to its own 455,113-unit figure; a federal extension of the encampment-initiative funding noted; and honesty flags added where re-verification could not re-locate a circulated figure rather than silently keeping it.

The full claims ledger, source list, and verification trail behind every number and quotation in this book are maintained in this project's records; this book's own receipt rows — every claim and source behind it, with their verification notes — are published alongside its source text in the public commons repository at github.com/unitetolove/commons, and every correction is published at unitetolove.ca/corrections.html.